

**BOOK ONE**  
**WOMB OF SHADOWS**

*A GOTNA Novel*

*“If you could hear every living thing at once—  
every breath, every heartbeat, every scream  
no one answered—  
would it sound like noise?  
Or would it sound like music?”*

— Provenance unknown  
Recovered from a frequency that should not exist

# CHAPTER ONE

## The Quiet Fracture

The baby did not cry.

That was the first thing Dr. Evelyn Hart noticed and the last thing she would ever forgive. Three weeks after the delivery, in the half-dark of the neonatal ward at Apex Genomics, Evelyn held her daughter against her chest and listened to the silence where a voice should have been. The monitors spoke instead—steady, indifferent beeps measuring a life in voltage. Somewhere down the corridor a centrifuge spun with the low patience of a machine that would outlast everyone in the building. The air smelled of rubbing alcohol and recycled breath and the particular staleness of a room where people wait for results that never come fast enough.

Nunnally was three weeks old. She weighed five pounds and four ounces. Her eyes were open.

They saw nothing.

Milky veils covered both irises, dense as cataracts, turning the world behind them to fog. Her mouth moved in small shapes—lips parting, tongue pressing forward, the mechanics of speech rehearsing in miniature without producing sound. No cry. No coo. Not even the thin, reedy wail that premature infants make, the one that sounds like a question. Just effort, meeting emptiness.

Her ears were malformed: delicate folds that had never finished closing, cartilage curled in on itself as though the body had lost interest partway through. And her arms—

Evelyn looked at the arms every time. She could not stop.

They ended in smooth, rounded nubs just below the elbows. The skin stretched taut and seamless over absence, as if the blueprint for the rest had simply been revoked. No scarring, no suggestion of trauma. Completion, refused.

The doctors used words like multifactorial and unprecedented and congenital syndrome of unknown etiology. Language shaped to sound like understanding while admitting none. Someone from genetics had mentioned a possible teratogenic event—environmental exposure during the first trimester—and someone else had quietly referenced Evelyn’s long hours in the RNA lab. They spoke the way witnesses describe a house fire: unanimous that it happened, silent on who struck the match.

Evelyn didn’t care what they called it. Naming had never rebuilt anything.

She pressed her lips to the baby’s temple. Nunnally’s skin was warm and thin, tasting of soap and the faint mineral salt of a body too new to have accumulated its own smell. Beneath it, something moved.

Not muscle. Not reflex. A low internal shifting, wet and rhythmic, like cartilage testing its own edges.

*Click.*

The sound was barely there. Organic. Intimate. Coming from inside the left nub, where the arm should have continued. A small, wet articulation—bone-against-bone, or something not yet bone, pressing outward in slow, blind repetition.

*Click. Click.*

Evelyn’s hand tightened on the baby’s back. She told herself it was normal. Settling tissue. Cartilage remnants. The body doing inventory on what it had and what it lacked.

But the sound didn't settle. It continued—even, patient, as if something inside the nub was knocking on a door it expected to open.

A nurse came in to adjust the IV and left without meeting Evelyn's eyes. The room dimmed as the overhead fluorescents cycled to their evening setting. Evelyn kept rocking, kept listening.

She was thirty-nine years old. She had spent the last eleven years at the frontier of messenger RNA therapeutics—designing molecular instruction sets that could reprogram living tissue at the cellular level. She had watched tumors dissolve under the right sequence. She had seen paralyzed nerve fibers refire after a single injection of a vector she'd built from scratch. She understood, with the certainty of someone who had done it, that the body was not fixed. It was not destiny. It was a draft, and drafts could be revised.

But all of that was academic medicine. Peer-reviewed. Ethics-approved. Conducted on consenting adults who signed waivers.

Almost all of it. There had been one exception—a nineteen-year-old at Johns Hopkins, three years ago, a spinal glioblastoma eating her alive faster than the review board could approve dose adjustments. Evelyn had gone off-protocol at two in the morning. A single unauthorized escalation. The girl's tumor shrank by forty percent. The girl lived. The review board did not care that the girl lived. They cared that Evelyn had made the decision alone, in the dark, answering to no authority but her own certainty. She was censured. She chose the door before they could push her through it. She told herself she would never cross that line again.

This was her daughter.

This was three weeks old, five pounds, and silent.

Evelyn opened the tablet on the side table with her free hand. The screen glowed with the latest vector simulation—a retinoic acid cascade she’d been refining in her off-hours, modeling it against axolotl regeneration data. The salamanders could regrow a severed limb in weeks: bone, nerve, muscle, skin, returned in full fidelity. Their secret was the blastema—a mass of dedifferentiated cells that formed at the wound site and rebuilt the structure from memory. Evelyn had been chasing a way to trigger that process in human tissue for three years. It had always been theoretical.

Now it was personal.

She scrolled through the payload architecture. Messenger RNA wrapped in lipid nanoparticles, targeted to the residual stem cells at the amputation plane. The sequence would instruct the cells to dedifferentiate, form a blastema, and begin rebuilding according to the body’s own developmental map. It was elegant. It was untested. It was wildly, recklessly premature.

She tapped the simulation’s RUN button and watched the probability curves bloom across the screen. Sixty-two percent viability. Up from forty-one last week.

Not enough for a clinical trial. Not enough for a journal. Not enough for anyone.

Enough for a mother who had already proven she would cross the line when the math was right.

“I’m going to fix you,” she whispered into Nunnally’s hair. The words were so quiet they barely disturbed the air. “I don’t care what it costs.”

The baby’s mouth moved once—a silent shape, round and open, as though she had heard and was trying to answer.

Inside the left nub, the clicking continued. Patient. Expectant.

Like something waiting to be let out.

\* \* \*

Fifty feet underground, the air tasted like a mistake someone had tried to sterilize.

Colonel Marcus Hart stood in Gestation Bay 4 of Project Forge and watched the thing in the pod die. It was dying the way classified projects always died—by centimeters, behind glass, while someone with rank stood nearby and pretended it wasn't happening.

Asset Zero floated in amber fluid, no larger than a man's fist. Its skin was translucent and veined with threads of pale light that flickered at uneven intervals, like a bulb on its way out. Gray flakes sloughed from its surface in lazy spirals, drifting through the fluid like ash from a fire no one had reported. The monitors scrolled in red: VIABILITY 43%. CELLULAR CASCADE ACCELERATING. REGRESSION CYCLE 7 OF 12.

The bunker was buried under the Virginia hills, accessed through a road that ended at a locked gate in a forest where even the birdsong went thin. The official entrance was labeled WATER TREATMENT FACILITY—AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL. It had never processed a drop. The unofficial entrance was a cargo elevator disguised as a grain silo. Marcus used neither. He used the third entrance, the one that wasn't in any schematic, because the kind of man who got assigned to Forge was the kind of man who knew things that didn't exist.

The air down here didn't smell like a hospital. It smelled of ozone, heated circuitry, and something else—faint, persistent, sweet in a way that made his back teeth itch. Like overripe fruit turning alcoholic. Like honey left in the sun until the sugar began to rot.

It had been getting stronger for weeks. The ventilation techs couldn't find the source. Marcus could. It was coming from the pod.

A young technician named Arnaud hovered at his elbow, talking too fast. “Regeneration markers are in freefall, sir. The axolotl-derived stem system keeps trying to rebuild, but there’s no anchor. The tissue rewrites itself and then collapses—like it can’t decide what it wants to be.”

“How long?”

“If it drops below forty percent, we’re looking at cascade failure within seventy-two hours. After that—” Arnaud made a small gesture, fingers opening, the universal shorthand for gone.

Marcus didn’t respond. He stood with his hands clasped behind his back, the posture they taught at West Point for moments when your face needed to say nothing. The military loved calm men. Calm men signed orders. Calm men watched things dissolve in jars and called it progress.

Project Forge’s mandate had always been explained in the cleanest possible language: regenerative warfighters, self-healing assets, bioadaptive defense platforms. Marcus had read the classified briefs underneath the clean language. He knew what Asset Zero was actually for.

The skin would secrete a resin—clear, beautiful, viscous as warm honey—that could harden on contact or remain tacky enough to coat any surface. The resin was a delivery system. A scratch from Asset Zero’s fingernail could introduce an engineered pathogen that bloomed into cancer in fourteen days. A palm pressed to a pane of glass could turn the glass into a long-range vector, anyone who touched it absorbing the payload through their skin. A kiss could rewrite the target’s hormone cascade, turning loyalty to compliance and compliance to worship.

And beneath the resin: the second brain. A neural lobe grown adjacent to the primary cortex, dedicated entirely to synthesis. It could design new molecular payloads in real time—analyzing a target’s biology, engineering a bespoke weapon, and secreting it through the skin in under a minute. A biological black box that thought in poisons.

Marcus had justified it the way soldiers justified everything: by imagining the alternative. Shadow wars in countries whose names never made the news. Proxy conflicts where body bags were bad optics. Asset Zero was supposed to end fights before they started—one operative, one handshake, one quiet dissolution. No coffins. No flags. No hearings.

But as he watched the gray flakes spiral in the amber fluid, the justification tasted different in his mouth. Sweeter. Thicker. Like the air in the vault.

He turned from the pod and walked the corridor toward his office, boots silent on polished concrete. He passed Adjunct Lab 4, the one that had been stripped to the rivets and sealed. The glass partition still held a faint bloom of condensation on the inside, though the room had been empty for fourteen months.

Captain Elias Reyes had sat in that room. Marcus had liked Reyes. Reyes smoked illegal Marlboros and quoted Kierkegaard and called the embryo “our little monster” with an affection that unsettled the review board.

*Give it a soul, Marc*, Reyes had said once, leaning back in his chair with smoke curling past his eyes. *Or it’s just meat.*

The review board had not appreciated this.

The Purge Protocol triggered twelve hours later. It was designed to be clean—a heavy, clear mist delivered through the ventilation system, metabolizing organic tissue on contact. Marcus hadn’t been present. He’d read the after-action report. It noted, with clinical efficiency, that the process took ninety-seven seconds and that the remains fit in a standard biohazard drum.

The report did not note that Reyes’s vocal cords dissolved first, or that the security camera captured eleven seconds of silent screaming before the face lost structural integrity.

Marcus had watched the footage once. He had not slept the same way since.



He reached his office—windowless, lit by a single strip of LED that turned everything the color of bad news—and sat at his desk. The red phone was already vibrating. It wasn't his service phone or his personal phone. It was the one that didn't ring, only pulsed, like a vein.

He opened the message.

*Asset regression at 43%. 72-hour window before cellular cascade failure. Deliver viable enhancer or initiate termination protocol. No exceptions.*

Termination protocol. He read it the way you read a diagnosis. Twice, slowly, looking for the exit that wasn't there.

Stand down meant audits. Audits meant scapegoats. Scapegoats meant the quiet thing that had happened to Reyes—the mist, the drum, the redacted file. Forge didn't retire loose ends. It dissolved them.

He set the phone down. He rubbed the bridge of his nose until his vision blurred. And in the blur, he saw her—Nunnally. The nubs. The milky eyes. The clicking inside the skin that Evelyn didn't know he'd noticed. Cells that were already doing what the Asset could not: rebuilding.

The Asset needed a compatible enhancer—human tissue already primed for regeneration, a biological key that could anchor the collapsing cascade. Not donor tissue. Not a culture dish. Something alive and specific and rare.

Something that shared his blood.

Marcus closed his eyes. The honey-rot sweetness thickened in his throat, and he realized, with a nausea he would never fully shake, that the solution and the sin were the same thing.

\* \* \*

He came home at dusk. The sedan's headlights swept across the colonial's front porch and caught the neighbor's holiday lights, red and green, still up three days past New Year's. The gravel drive crunched under the tires. A normal sound. A safe sound. The kind of sound that belonged to a life he was about to steal from.

Inside, the house smelled of reheated Thai food and baby powder. Evelyn was on the couch, Nunnally bundled against her shoulder, a tablet balanced on the armrest showing vector readouts that pulsed with soft color. She looked up when he entered. The exhaustion in her face had passed through tiredness into something architectural—built in, load-bearing, part of who she was now.

“You're late,” she said.

“Budget review ran over.”

He kissed her temple. She tasted of salt. He kissed Nunnally's forehead. The baby's skin was warmer than it should have been—not fever-warm, but active-warm, like an engine idling beneath the surface.

“She's responding,” Evelyn said. She shifted the swaddle to show him the left nub. In the lamplight, the skin looked tighter than yesterday, stretched over a ridge that hadn't been there last week. Pink. Raw. Undeniable. “The latest vector is taking hold. Faster than the models predicted.”

Marcus stared at the ridge. His stomach did something complicated.

Because he recognized it. Not from Evelyn's research. From the graphs on his desk at Forge. The same cellular signature. The same regenerative aggression. The exact biological frequency the Asset was starving for.

He forced his voice steady. “That's incredible, Eve.”

She smiled—the first real smile he’d seen in weeks, bright and exhausted and terrifying in its hope—and leaned into him. “It’s working, Marcus. It’s actually working.”

He held them both and said nothing. The house creaked in its winter way, pipes adjusting, vents breathing. Through the living room window, snow began to fall—thick flakes drifting through the streetlight’s cone, silent and indifferent.

On the changing table in the nursery, a folded square of gauze sat beside the alcohol swabs. Two small rust-brown spots, each no larger than a teardrop, marked its center.

From Evelyn’s latest draw. Nunnally’s blood.

Marcus had noticed it when he’d carried the baby in. He’d noted its position the way a man notes an exit in a crowded room—automatically, without deciding to, filed under a heading he hadn’t written yet.

\* \* \*

He waited until the house was asleep.

Two in the morning. January cold pressing against the windowpanes like a hand testing for weakness. The furnace had cycled off and the air in the hallway carried the particular silence of a home where everyone is breathing and no one is awake. Evelyn’s breathing, slow and shallow from the bedroom. Nunnally’s breathing, faster, lighter, from the nursery at the end of the hall. The sequencer on the dresser exhaled its low mechanical hymn, a sound that had become so constant it had merged with the architecture of the house, indistinguishable from the walls.

Marcus stood in the hallway in his socks. He had not turned on a light.

The nursery door was open. It was always open—Evelyn insisted, needed to hear the monitors, needed the corridor of sound between her sleeping body and her daughter’s. Marcus

moved through it now, each step deliberate, weight on the balls of his feet, the muscle memory of a man who had been trained to enter rooms where the occupants should not know he was there.

Moonlight came through the blinds in silver bars, falling across the bassinet like the ribs of a cage. The changing table stood against the far wall, its surface cluttered with the small debris of desperate medicine: syringes still in their sterile packaging, alcohol swabs, a portable centrifuge the size of a coffee maker, and the gauze.

The gauze.

Two rust-colored spots on white cotton. His daughter's blood, drawn twelve hours ago from a heel so small that the lancet had looked obscene against it. Evelyn had been careful—always careful, always precise, even when her hands shook—and she had set the gauze aside for disposal and then forgotten it in the fog of exhaustion.

Marcus crossed the room. Six steps. Each one the length of a decision he was pretending not to make.

He stood over the changing table and looked down at the gauze. In the moonlight the blood spots were almost black. They were so small. That was the obscenity of it—how little was needed. A few microliters. A stain no larger than a tear. Enough to anchor a cascade. Enough to wake a weapon. Enough to trade a daughter's cells for a monster's survival.

His hand hovered.

His fingers trembled. Not the gross shaking of fear—a fine, high-frequency vibration, the precise tremor of a system under load. He pressed his thumb against his forefinger until the nail whitened. The tremor stopped. He didn't let himself notice that suppressing it required effort it shouldn't have.

He could hear his own pulse now, thick in his ears, and underneath it—or maybe inside it—the ghost of the honey-rot smell from the bunker. Faint. Persistent. As if the sweetness had followed him home and was standing just behind his shoulder, breathing warm and patient against his neck.

He thought of Evelyn in the next room. The trust in her body—turned toward the wall, arm outstretched across the mattress where he should be lying. She had married a soldier. She had understood compartmentalization, security clearances, the weight of things that couldn't be said. She had never imagined that the unsaid thing would be this.

He thought of Reyes. The empty office. The biohazard drum.

He thought: one drop. That's all. One drop and the cascade stabilizes and the project lives and I go home tomorrow and kiss my wife and hold my daughter and none of this has to become what it's becoming.

The justification assembled itself in his chest with the smooth precision of a rifle being fieldstripped and reassembled. Patriotic: this protects the country. Paternal: this protects the family. Visionary: this is how the future is built, one small sacrifice at a time, by men willing to carry the weight.

Each piece clicked into place. Each one tasted sweet.

A darker thought moved behind the others, cold and fluid: perhaps this was how gods were born. Through small thefts. Through fathers who loved their daughters and stole from them anyway, because the alternative was disappearing into a drum.

Marcus's fingers closed around the gauze.

His foot caught the centrifuge cord.

The machine shifted half an inch on the table—a small, dense sound, metal on laminate, absurdly loud in the dark. Marcus froze. His pulse detonated. In the bassinet, Nunnally stirred.

Three seconds. He counted them because counting was what you did when your body wanted to run and your training wouldn't let it. The centrifuge settled. The house held its breath.

It was lighter than he expected. Almost nothing. A whisper of cotton and dried blood that fit in his palm like a secret too small to confess.

He slipped it into the pocket of his robe.

Behind him, in the bassinet, Nunnally's face had turned toward him. Her milky eyes, open in the dark, aimed at the space where his hand had been.

And inside her left nub, the clicking stopped.

Not faded. Not slowed. Stopped—the way a clock stops, all at once, in the middle of a tick. The silence it left was louder than the sound had been.

Marcus froze. The gauze burned in his pocket like a coal.

For three seconds—he counted them, because counting was what you did when your body wanted to run and your training wouldn't let it—he and his daughter existed in the same silence. Her eyes, sightless, pointed at him. His hand, guilty, pressed against his pocket. The moonlight held them both in its silver cage.

Then Nunnally's mouth opened. Not the usual silent working, the formless shapes that Evelyn read as hunger or discomfort. This was a single shape. Round. Deliberate. A vowel pressed against the air without sound, but with intent so clear it landed in Marcus's chest like a fist.

*Ah.*

The nub twitched once. The clicking resumed—faster now, a rapid-fire articulation, as if whatever was inside had received new instructions.

Marcus left the nursery without breathing. He closed the door to three inches, exactly as Evelyn kept it, and stood in the hallway with his hand over his pocket, pressing the gauze against his thigh as though pressure could undo what he'd done.

The house settled around him. Cold and quiet and complicit.

\* \* \*

He drove to Forge before dawn.

The roads were empty, glazed with frost that turned the headlights into smears. The sedan's heater struggled against a cold that seemed to come from inside the car. Marcus drove with one hand. The other rested on the gauze in his coat pocket, thumb moving over the dried blood spots in slow circles, the way a man fingers a rosary when the prayer has stopped being voluntary.

The descent into the bunker took ninety seconds. Retinal scan, voice print, biometric. The elevator cage dropped through cold air that grew warmer and sweeter as he descended, the honey-rot thickening until he could taste it on the roof of his mouth—not unpleasant, not yet, just present, the way a new flavor is present before you decide whether you like it.

Gestation Bay 4. Four in the morning. The pod glowed amber in the darkened vault.

Asset Zero was worse. The fluid had clouded overnight, gray with cellular debris. The embryo had drawn inward, compacting, a knot of failing tissue that pulsed at the wrong rhythm—too slow, too irregular, the heartbeat of something forgetting how to live.

Marcus donned nitrile gloves. He moved to the infusion console with the economy of a man who has decided to stop thinking. He unwrapped the gauze. He scraped the dried blood into

the saline reservoir with a sterile blade, watching the rust-brown flakes dissolve into pale pink. He primed the infusion line. The solution traveled through clear tubing, snaking toward the pod, catching the amber light like a vein of diluted sunset.

He pressed INITIATE.

The fluid entered the pod through a port at the base. For a long moment—thirty seconds, forty—nothing changed. The monitors continued their scrolling elegy. The gray flakes continued their drift. The embryo continued its slow contraction.

Marcus stared through the plexiglass and felt the specific despair of a man who has committed an unforgivable act for nothing.

Then the fluid moved.

Not drift. Not current. The amber solution surrounding the embryo began to rotate—slowly at first, then with gathering urgency, as though something at the center had begun to pull. The gray flakes reversed course, spiraling inward, reabsorbed into tissue that had been shedding them for weeks. The monitors shrieked. INTEGRITY SURGE. CELLULAR DENSITY SHIFTING. VIABILITY 51%. 58%. 67%.

The embryo uncurled.

It happened in stages, each one punctuated by a sound Marcus would hear in his dreams for the rest of his life. The skin split along the dorsal line—a wet, precise unzipping, seam opening from skull to tailbone—and from the split, new tissue erupted. Bone, threading through translucent flesh like frost forming on glass. Muscle, layering in red ribbons. A torso elongating, limbs unfurling, fingers spreading. At the base of the skull, a second mass swelled—the neural lobe, the weapons brain, bulging behind the brainstem with the obscene confidence of a tumor that knew it was wanted.



The growth was industrial. Mechanical in its speed, biological in its wetness. The sound of it filled the vault—a sustained, tearing, layered noise, like fabric ripping underwater.

In under four minutes, the thing in the pod was no longer an embryo.

It was a boy. Pale and hairless and floating in fluid that had turned from amber to the color of old gold. His body was lean, proportioned like a teenager's, though he had been tissue four minutes ago. His eyes were closed. His chest rose and fell in the fluid with the slow rhythm of something that had been alive much longer than it had.

Along his neck, small translucent glands had formed in neat rows, already glistening with a clear secretion that caught the light like dew.

The resin glands. Functional. Full.

The honey-rot smell hit Marcus like a wall. It was no longer faint. It was lush, overwhelming, sweet enough to coat the back of his throat, and underneath the sweetness—so far underneath you had to be paying attention—the crisp electric bite of ozone. Like standing too close to a transformer. Like the air before lightning.

The boy opened his eyes.

They were fractured blue, shot through with veins of electric azure that pulsed once, twice, like a signal finding its frequency. They locked onto Marcus through the plexiglass with a focus that was not newborn. Not confused. Not searching.

The eyes of something that had been waiting for exactly this.

The boy pressed his palm against the glass. Fingers splayed wide, new and pale and perfect.

And Marcus felt it.

A hook behind his ribs. Not pain—deeper, more structural, as if a tendon he hadn't known existed had been seized and pulled taut. His hand rose without his permission and pressed against the glass opposite the boy's palm.

The word arrived in his skull the way a migraine arrives—sudden, total, filling every available space.

*Father.*

It wasn't sound. It wasn't language. It was a pressure that carried meaning, the way a shockwave carries heat. Marcus's vision blurred. His mouth flooded with the taste of honey and rot and copper and somewhere, underneath it all, the mineral salt of a baby's skin.

Nunnally's skin.

Because the bridge was not one-way.

\* \* \*

Thirty-seven miles away, in the silver-barred dark of the nursery, Nunnally Hart opened her mouth.

She did not cry. She had never cried. But the clicking inside her left nub accelerated into something new—a rapid, rhythmic percussion, bone-on-bone-on-something-that-was-not-yet-bone, as if the limb she didn't have was trying to build itself in real time.

Her milky eyes stared at the ceiling. For the first time since birth, something behind them shifted—not sight, not yet, but a change in the quality of the blankness, like the difference between a television that is off and a television that is on but receiving no signal.

The sequencer on the dresser chimed a reading it had never produced. Evelyn's tablet, on the nightstand in the next room, lit up with an alert she would find in the morning and stare at for

a long time: a spike in Nunnally's cellular activity so extreme that the software flagged it as a sensor malfunction.

It was not a malfunction.

It was an answer.

Thirty-seven miles south, in a bunker that didn't exist, a boy made of her blood pressed his hand to the glass and called a stranger Father. And in the nursery that smelled of soap and alcohol and the faintest trace of something sweet, a baby girl made of the same blood felt the call land in her body like a tuning fork struck in an adjacent room—not heard, but felt. In the teeth. In the bones. In the space where her arms should have been.

The clicking grew louder.

Evelyn slept through it. She would sleep through many things in the weeks to come.

The house breathed around them both—vents sighing, pipes ticking, the old colonial settling into its foundations the way it had for sixty years. But the breath was different now. There was a frequency in it that had not been there before. A low hum, below the threshold of hearing, that made the fillings in the walls vibrate at intervals too regular to be random.

In the basement, the circuit breaker tripped and reset itself.

In the nursery, Nunnally's right nub twitched.

And the clicking, steady now, patient now, continued through the dark—a conversation in a language that had no words yet, between a daughter and a brother she had never met, across a bridge their father had built from stolen blood.

The fracture had begun.

## SYNAPSE 01

### THE CALCULUS OF ZERO

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[SOURCE: PROJECT FORGE / INTERNAL MEMORANDUM / EYES ONLY]

FROM: Gen. H. Vance, DARPA Oversight

TO: Col. Marcus Hart, Forge Operations Lead

DATE: 2026-01-03

CLASSIFICATION: UMBRA / NOFORN / ORCON

RE: Asset Zero – Viability Status and Contingency

Colonel,

Asset Zero viability index: 43.2%. Decline of 12.7% over 96 hours. Cascade failure projected within 72 hours absent compatible biological enhancer.

Enhancer requirements unchanged. Living human tissue with active regenerative markers compatible with axolotl-derived architecture. Standard donor tissue rejected across 14 trials. The cascade requires a biological anchor: tissue that has survived a regenerative event and can serve as stabilization template.

Personnel are reminded that Termination Protocol (ref: FORGE-TP-7) activates upon cascade failure. All associated personnel, documentation, and biological materials will be processed per standard containment. Reference: Case File 11-A (Capt. Reyes, E.).

No exceptions. No appeals.

72-hour extension granted. This extension is final.

Howard

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*[ADDENDUM – Col. Hart's copy, lower margin, pencil:]*

*What does it want to be?*

*[SECOND ADDENDUM – Arnaud's copy, ballpoint, cramped:]*

*It was humming today. Not from the speakers. From the glass. I put my hand on the pod and felt it in my fingers like a phone vibrating. Nobody else noticed or maybe nobody wanted to. I didn't log it. I keep not logging things.*

# CHAPTER TWO

## **Whispers in the Flesh**

Evelyn woke to an alert she didn't understand.

The tablet on the nightstand was pulsing amber, the screen filled with a readout that looked like a seismograph during an earthquake. Nunnally's cellular activity—baseline metabolic rate, mitotic index, the regenerative markers Evelyn had been tracking with the obsessive precision of a woman who had replaced sleep with data—had spiked at 4:11 a.m. A single vertical line, sharp as a scream, that dwarfed every reading she'd taken in three weeks of monitoring.

The software had flagged it as a sensor malfunction. Evelyn sat on the edge of the bed, hair unwashed, wearing the same T-shirt she'd slept in for two days, and stared at the spike until the screen dimmed.

It was not a malfunction. She knew that the way she knew her own heartbeat—not through evidence but through the particular dread of a scientist who has seen data that shouldn't exist.

The house was quiet. Too quiet. Marcus's side of the bed was empty but still warm, the sheets creased in the shape of a body that had left recently. His keys were gone from the bowl on the dresser. His coat was gone from the hook by the door. She noted these absences the way she'd learned to note everything lately: automatically, without alarm, cataloged in the growing file of things about her husband that didn't quite fit.

She went to the nursery.

Nunnally was awake. That was the first strangeness. The baby almost never woke before Evelyn came in—she existed in a world without light or sound, and her sleep-wake cycle had become a kind of tide, governed by internal rhythms that had nothing to do with dawn. But this morning her milky eyes were open, aimed at the ceiling, and her body was radiating heat through the swaddle like a stone that had been sitting in sunlight.

Evelyn lifted her and felt it immediately. The baby was heavier. Not by much—ounces, maybe—but Evelyn had held this body every day for three weeks, and her arms were calibrated to its weight the way a jeweler’s hands are calibrated to grams. Something had been added.

She unwrapped the swaddle.

The left nub had changed overnight. The ridge she’d shown Marcus the evening before—the pink, raw line of new cartilage—had thickened. It was no longer a suggestion. It was a declaration. The skin had stretched and thinned over something structural beneath it, something with dimension, with intent. Evelyn could see the shadows of new vasculature branching beneath the translucent surface—tiny rivers of blood feeding territory that hadn’t existed twelve hours ago.

Her breath caught. She pressed her thumb gently against the ridge. It was firm. Warm. It pressed back.

The clicking inside the nub was louder now. Not the tentative bone-on-bone she’d been telling herself was settling cartilage. This was purposeful. Rhythmic. A construction sound—small machines at work inside her daughter’s body, building something with a confidence that Evelyn’s own research could not explain.

Because the timeline was wrong.

Evelyn's vector was good. She knew it was good. But it was designed for incremental progress—millimeters of tissue over weeks, guided by careful dosing and constant monitoring. What she was looking at now was not incremental. It was aggressive. As if something had turbocharged the process overnight, flooding Nunnally's cells with a regenerative urgency that went beyond anything the vector alone could produce.

She carried the baby to the dining room table—her other battlefield, the one covered in petri dishes and vials and the portable sequencer that never stopped humming—and began running diagnostics. Blood draw from the heel, capillary tube, centrifuge spinning while she rocked Nunnally with one arm and read numbers with the other.

The numbers didn't make sense. Mitotic rate tripled. Blastema density off the chart. Growth factors she hadn't introduced showing up in concentrations that shouldn't be possible without an external catalyst.

Something was feeding the process. Something that wasn't her.

Evelyn stared at the readouts and felt two things collide in her chest: the thrill of a scientist watching the impossible happen, and the terror of a mother realizing she was not the only force acting on her child's body.

She chose the thrill. She chose it the way you choose a door in a burning building—not because you know it's safe, but because the alternative is standing still.

"All right," she said to Nunnally, her voice steadier than her hands. "If you're ready, I'm ready."

She reached for the syringe.

\* \* \*

The vector was clear as water and as precise as a sentence.

Evelyn had spent eleven nights refining it—stripping redundancies, tightening the messenger payload, adjusting the lipid envelope until the nanoparticles would find their targets with the accuracy of heat-seeking rounds. She had modeled it against every piece of axolotl regeneration data in the public literature and several pieces that weren't public at all, borrowed from old files her former colleague Dr. Lena Voss had left behind before her death. The sequence didn't just repair. It insisted.

She swabbed the left nub with alcohol. Nunnally's skin was so thin here that Evelyn could see the shadow of the new structure beneath it—a dark shape, branching, like a tree seen through fog.

She hesitated. The dosage she'd prepared was aggressive—forty percent above the model's safe ceiling, a ceiling she had set herself, carefully, conservatively, the way she'd been taught. The way she'd promised herself she would always work, after Hopkins.

The math justified the risk. It always did, if you were smart enough and desperate enough to build the right equation.

She slid the needle in. The baby didn't flinch. She had never flinched from needles. Evelyn sometimes wondered if Nunnally's damaged nerves were a mercy—the body shielding itself from the full cost of what was being done to it.

She depressed the plunger. Slow. Steady. A controlled introduction, not a flood.

Then she waited.

The sequencer hummed. The house was still. Through the dining room windows, January light fell in pale shafts across the table, catching the edges of the vials and throwing tiny rainbows across the wall—absurdly beautiful in a room that smelled of antiseptic and old takeout.



Thirty seconds. Nothing.

Sixty seconds. Evelyn's fingers found Nunnally's pulse at the wrist—fast, steady, the engine running hot.

Ninety seconds.

Then a tremor passed through the nub. Not a twitch—a ripple, originating deep, radiating outward through the tissue like a stone dropped into still water. The ridge of cartilage she'd been monitoring shifted. Visibly. The skin stretched, went white at the edges, and then—

*Schick.*

The sound was small and precise and wet. Like a seam opening along a line that had been scored in advance. A split appeared at the tip of the nub—clean, bloodless for one heartbeat, then welling with a single bead of bright red that caught the morning light and held it like a jewel.

From the split, something pushed outward.

Cartilage first. Pink and raw and glistening, emerging with the slow inevitability of a plant breaking through soil. It didn't look like bone. It looked like the idea of bone—a sketch made of living tissue, translucent enough that Evelyn could see the nerve filaments threading through it in real time, firing in tiny, silent sparks, like bioluminescence in deep ocean.

Then the cartilage hardened. She watched it happen—watched the tissue shift from gel to solid in a gradient that moved from the base outward, opaque white chasing translucent pink the way ice forms across the surface of a lake. Proto-bone. Real bone. Her daughter's body remembering a shape it had never been allowed to take and building it now with a furious, delicate precision that made Evelyn's hands shake and her vision blur.

The bud lengthened. Skin stretched to follow, impossibly elastic, resealing behind the growth as if it had done this a thousand times. Blood vessels raced to keep up—she could see

them branching in real time, red threads chasing the new tissue like vines following sunlight. Muscle fibers layered themselves in thin red ribbons, contracting experimentally, testing tension.

A finger.

It was unmistakably a finger. Small and new and glistening with the fluid of its own arrival. It extended from the bud at an angle that looked, for one impossible second, like a hand reaching out of a grave.

Then it flexed.

The flex was instinctive—not directed, not purposeful, just a new nerve firing for the first time and discovering that it was connected to something that could move. The finger curled inward, trembled, uncurled. Curled again. Seeking.

Evelyn's sob broke free before she could stop it—a sound that was part triumph and part grief and part raw animal relief, the sound of a woman who had spent three weeks holding a broken thing and had just felt it begin to mend in her hands.

She held Nunnally closer. The baby's milky eyes were open, and the veils had thinned—not cleared, not yet, but thinned, the way frost thins on a windshield when the defroster kicks in. Behind the white, the faintest ghost of blue. Iris, emerging. Color returning to a world that had been colorless.

The new finger found Evelyn's thumb. Touched it. Wrapped around it with the slow, testing grip of a creature learning what it means to hold on.

Evelyn wept. She wept without sound, the way she'd trained herself to weep in the NICU when the nurses were watching—tears only, no noise, because noise was weakness and weakness was a luxury she could not afford. The tears fell on Nunnally's forehead and the baby's mouth

made that silent shape again—the round, deliberate vowel, pressed against the air like a word trying to be born.

For one perfect, uncontaminated moment, the world was nothing but a mother and a daughter and a finger that had not existed five minutes ago, curling around a thumb, holding on.

Evelyn didn't notice the smell.

It was faint. Background. A sweetness in the air that could have been anything—the takeout containers in the trash, the dregs of coffee on the counter, the chemical warmth of the sequencer running hot. She breathed it in without registering it, the way you breathe the first trace of smoke before your brain decides it's fire.

By the time she noticed it, it would be too late.

But that was tomorrow's problem. Right now, there was only the finger, and the grip, and the sound of clicking inside the nub accelerating into a hum that was almost—almost—music.

\* \* \*

Thirty-seven miles south, the thing that had been Asset Zero breathed on its own for the first time.

The pod had been drained at 0600. The amber fluid sluiced into reclamation tanks, leaving the boy—it was difficult not to call it a boy now, though every protocol document still referred to it as “the Asset”—lying on the curved glass floor of the cylinder, pale and still and steaming faintly in the cold vault air. His eyes were closed. His chest rose and fell. Along his neck, the translucent glands pulsed in slow rhythm, secreting a thin film that caught the overhead lights and turned them soft gold.

The vault smelled like a greenhouse in August. Warm. Alive. Wrong.

A security detail ringed the pod at ten-meter intervals, rifles angled at a thing that looked like a sleeping teenager and registered on their thermal scopes as 104.8 degrees Fahrenheit. Too hot for human. Too still for threat. Too new for anyone to have a protocol for.

Colonel Hart had left instructions: no direct contact. Observation only. Core samples at arm's length. Do not speak to the Asset. Do not respond if the Asset speaks.

Arnaud was running the early diagnostics when the morning rotation arrived. He handed the clipboard to Dr. Maren Seo with the particular relief of a man who had been alone with something he didn't want to be alone with.

"Core temp 104.8. Neural activity off the scale—every region lit simultaneously. I flagged it as anomalous but it's been sustained for two hours." He paused. "He hasn't moved. But I don't think he's sleeping."

Maren took the clipboard without comment.

She was thirty-one, third-year Forge rotation, the kind of scientist who had gotten into military biotech because the private sector wouldn't fund her real interests: liminal biology, the threshold states between growth and collapse where cells made decisions that looked, if you squinted, like choices. She wore her hair tied back so tight it pulled at her temples, and she carried her coffee in a steel thermos because the ceramic mugs in the break room always smelled faintly of the nutrient baths.

She approached the pod with her tablet and her training and the particular calm of a woman who had spent two years cataloging failures in this vault and had stopped expecting anything that required awe.

She pressed her badge to the access panel. The pod's outer shell retracted in quadrants, exposing the inner glass. The smell hit her first—thick, sweet, layered, like walking into a room

where someone had been baking bread and burning candles simultaneously. She noted it on her tablet without comment. Her job was baselines, not poetry.

She ran the handheld scanner along the Asset's torso at the prescribed distance: thirty centimeters, no closer. Core temperature, dermal conductivity, respiratory rate. The numbers were extraordinary and she logged them with steady hands. Heart rate 42—bradycardic by human standards, but the Asset's cardiovascular architecture wasn't human. Oxygen saturation 99.8 percent. Neural activity—

She paused. Looked at the readout. Looked again.

Neural activity was off the scale. Not elevated. Not spiking. Sustained. Every region lit simultaneously, a level of parallel processing that in a human brain would indicate a grand mal seizure. In the Asset, it looked like thinking. All of it, all at once, about everything.

She noted it. Moved on. The scan swept down to the limbs, the hands, the resin glands at the neck—

The Asset opened his eyes.

There was no transition. No flutter, no drowsy surfacing. One moment closed, the next open. Fractured blue, veined with light, focused on her face with a clarity that felt less like sight and more like being read.

Maren's hand stopped moving. The scanner hung in the air between them.

Protocol was explicit: do not respond. She knew this. She had signed the page. She stared at the readout on her tablet and tried to pretend the eyes were not on her.

But the warmth shifted. It was subtle—not a temperature change on the scanner, not something the instruments would catch. It was a change in quality. The air between Maren and

the glass became denser, closer, the way air changes in a small room when someone steps nearer. A pressure that wasn't physical. A proximity that had nothing to do with distance.

Her breath fogged the glass, and in the fog, she saw his hand move. Slow. Not toward her. Toward the glass itself. Palm flat. Fingers open.

She thought, absurdly: *he's lonely*.

The thought was not hers. She knew that with the same certainty she knew her own name. It had arrived in her mind fully formed, wearing her voice, using her syntax, indistinguishable from her own thinking except for the fact that she had not been thinking it until she was.

She stepped back. The air thinned. The warmth receded. The Asset's eyes closed, slow as a door being pulled shut by someone who wanted you to see it close.

Maren logged the rest of her readings in the corridor, leaning against the wall with her thermos pressed to her chest, her hands steady and her heart doing something her training had no name for.

She did not mention the thought in her report. She filed it under the growing category of things about Forge that she would deal with later.

Later never came. But that's a different chapter.

\* \* \*

Marcus came home at seven. Evelyn met him at the door holding Nunnally like a trophy.

"Look," she said. Just the one word, but it carried the weight of every sleepless night and every failed simulation and every moment she had spent in the NICU whispering promises into hair that smelled of hospital soap.

She held up the baby's left arm. The bud had progressed since morning. The single finger had been joined by the ghost of a second, a translucent ridge emerging from the blastema with

the slow confidence of a tide that knows exactly where it's going. The skin had sealed over the original split. The clicking had settled into a steady rhythm, quick and even, like a heartbeat's apprentice learning the trade.

Marcus stood in the doorway with his coat still on and snow melting in his hair and looked at his daughter's hand and said nothing for a long time.

He was thinking about a boy in a pod. A boy with the same regenerative signature. A boy who had opened his eyes six hours ago and pressed his palm to glass and spoken a word directly into the center of Marcus's skull.

He was thinking about how the finger growing on Nunnally's arm looked exactly like the fingers that had splayed against the plexiglass.

He was thinking: *what have I connected.*

"Marcus?" Evelyn's smile faltered. "What's wrong? This is good. This is—this is everything."

He blinked. He manufactured a smile that used all the right muscles and none of the right feelings. "It's incredible," he said. "She's incredible. You're incredible."

He took the baby. Held her against his chest. Nunnally's new finger—wet, pink, impossibly delicate—curled against his collar and gripped the fabric with a strength that startled him.

And he felt it again. The hook. Fainter than in the vault, but unmistakable—a tug behind his ribs, a tightening of something that connected his body to a place thirty-seven miles south, where a boy he had built from his daughter's blood was lying in a drained pod, eyes closed, glands pulsing, learning what his own hands could do.

The baby's grip tightened.

Marcus looked down at the finger on his collar. It was so small. So new. So much like the fingers he'd seen through the glass.

Evelyn was already back at the dining table, pulling up readouts, talking fast—dosing schedules, growth projections, the possibility that full limb regeneration could be achieved within weeks, not months. Her voice was bright and alive in a way it hadn't been since before the delivery. Hope had returned to the house like electricity to a dead circuit, buzzing through every room, making the lights feel warmer and the walls feel closer.

Marcus listened. He nodded. He held the baby.

And somewhere beneath the baby powder and the reheated food and the medicinal bite of alcohol swabs, he caught it—faint as a rumor, sweet as a lie—the smell. His smell. The one that had followed him out of the bunker and into the car and through the door and into the house where his wife was celebrating a miracle that was half his theft.

Nunnally's milky eyes were open. The fog in them had thinned further—he could see the blue now, a vein of color emerging from the white like a crack in ice. She was looking at him. Not seeing—not yet—but oriented. Aimed.

Her mouth opened. The silent shape.

*Ah.*

The same vowel. The same intent. This time, Marcus heard something underneath it—a pressure, not from Nunnally's throat but from somewhere deeper, resonating through the shared architecture of blood and theft: a second voice, layered beneath hers, harmonizing in a key that human vocal cords could not produce.



Not a word. Not yet. Just presence. Something behind his daughter's eyes that had not been there yesterday, looking out through her the way a tenant looks out through a window in a building they didn't build.

Marcus held the baby closer and told himself it was love he was feeling.

Love, and nothing else.

The house breathed. The sequencer hummed. Outside, the snow continued to fall, covering everything in white, burying the evidence of every footprint, every tire track, every path that led from this house to the place where the fracture had begun.

In the basement, the circuit breaker tripped and reset itself for the second time in twelve hours. The first had been at 4:11 a.m., when the spike hit Nunnally's readings. The second was now, at 7:14 p.m., the moment Marcus crossed the threshold with the smell still in his coat. Both events lasted exactly 1.86 seconds—the propagation time for a signal traveling at the speed of nerve conduction across a distance of thirty-seven miles.

Nobody noticed. Nobody connected the times.

## **SYNAPSE 02**

### *The Phantom Limb*

[SOURCE: Private Research Journal / Dr. Evelyn Hart / Unencrypted]

LOCATION: Hart Residence, Arlington, VA

NOTE: Recovered from dining room table. Pp. 1–12 intact. Pp. 13–18 missing. Clean cuts.

#### ***Jan 3 — 11:47 PM***

V7.4 administered 0800. Injection site stable. No inflammation. Blastema density 340 cells/mm<sup>3</sup> (12x baseline, consistent w/ Voss 2019 axolotl data). First visible bud 0817. Cartilaginous. Confirmed palpation + US.

Should be documenting through proper channels. I know. I will. When she's ready.

#### ***Jan 4 — 2:13 AM***

Can't sleep. Checked N. 3x since midnight. Bud +3mm since 2200 measurement. Rate inconsistent w/ vector payload release curve. Something accelerating beyond what I introduced. Possible: (1) endogenous GF spike from vector integration, (2) unknown synergistic pathway via retinoic acid seq., (3) external catalyst.

Option 3 least likely. Can't stop thinking about it.

#### ***Jan 5 — 6:02 AM***

First digit. Functional grip reflex confirmed 0547. She held my thumb.

Writing this one-handed. Not putting her down.

Second digit emerging. Growth rate NOT decreasing. Internal sounds changed — clicking now continuous low-freq hum, almost tonal. Measured 18.3 Hz. Below audible. Feel it through her skin when I hold her against my sternum.

#### ***Jan 5 — 11:58 PM***

Marcus home late. Smelled different. Sweet, under the deodorant. Said break room has new air freshener.

Didn't push it. Too happy. N. gripped his collar for four minutes. Four minutes of a hand that didn't exist a week ago.

#### ***Jan 6 — 3:15 AM***

Circuit breaker tripped again. Third time. Went to basement to reset. Water pipes vibrating. Not pressure — resonance. Palm flat on copper: steady rhythm. 18.3 Hz.

Same frequency as N.'s nub.

Stood there a long time.

*[FINAL ENTRY — undated, margin, different pen:]*

*It's working. So why am I afraid?*

# CHAPTER THREE

## The Intern

The girl who came to the door was not what Evelyn expected.

The application had been impressive—unnervingly so for a sixteen-year-old. Perfect scores in molecular biology and organic chemistry from the accelerated program at Thomas Jefferson. A recommendation letter from the department chair that used the word “extraordinary” three times without apparent embarrassment. A personal statement so precisely written it read less like a teenager’s college supplement and more like a grant proposal from someone who had already been rejected once and was not going to make the same mistakes.

But the girl standing on the porch at nine in the morning on January seventh, wearing a coat too thin for the weather and holding a messenger bag against her hip like a shield, did not look extraordinary. She looked careful. She looked like someone who had learned to take up as little space as possible and had gotten very good at it.

“Elara Voss?”

“Dr. Hart. Thank you for the opportunity.”

The voice was steady. The eyes were not. They moved—quick, cataloging—across the doorframe, the foyer, the coat hooks, the line of shoes by the mat. Not nervous. Systematic. The way Evelyn herself scanned a new dataset: looking for the shape of what she was about to enter.

Evelyn stepped aside. “Come in. It’s freezing.”

Elara crossed the threshold.

She stopped.

It was barely a pause—less than a second, a hitch in her stride that could have been a foot catching on the mat or an adjustment to the warmth of the house after the January air. But something happened in that moment, something that registered in the girl's body before it reached her face. Her shoulders dropped. Not relaxed—released, the way a fist unclenches when the thing it was bracing against doesn't come.

Elara Voss had lived with a noise in her body for five years.

Not a sound she could describe to a doctor, because she had tried, and the doctors had looked at her the way doctors look at teenagers who have silver scars on their wrists—with a careful, practiced kindness that assumes the problem is psychological and the prescription is patience. The noise was deeper than hearing. It lived in the tissue itself: a low, directionless static, like a television tuned to a dead channel, broadcasting from inside her bones. Some days it was a whisper. Some days it was a roar. It had been with her since the day in Lab 4 when the mist had touched her skin and the world had caught fire and then gone very, very quiet.

She had never told anyone what the noise actually felt like, because the closest comparison was one no sixteen-year-old could make without being hospitalized: it felt like homesickness for a place she had never been.

Standing in the foyer of the Hart residence, the noise stopped.

Not faded. Not dimmed. Stopped—the way a headache stops, all at once, leaving behind a silence so total it has its own weight. The static in her bones went flat. The low, grinding ache that she had carried in her wrists, her jaw, the base of her skull since she was eleven years old simply ceased, as though someone had found the frequency she was tuned to and matched it.

Elara stood very still and breathed.

The house smelled of coffee and antiseptic and baby powder and something else—faint, sweet, underneath everything, like a note in a chord you only hear if you stop listening for the melody. She breathed it in and felt her pulse slow to a rhythm she did not recognize as her own.

“Are you all right?” Evelyn was watching her.

“Fine.” Elara adjusted the bag on her shoulder. “Sorry. Long bus ride.”

She followed Evelyn into the house and did not look back at the door.

\* \* \*

The dining room had been converted into a laboratory with the particular desperation of someone who could not wait for proper equipment.

Evelyn’s setup sprawled across the oak table like the aftermath of a very organized explosion: petri dishes in numbered rows, a portable centrifuge trailing cables to a power strip, vials of clear solution arranged by date in a plastic rack, a sequencer the size of a hardcover novel humming steadily on a folded towel. Stacks of printouts covered one end of the table—graphs, chromatography readouts, molecular models annotated in Evelyn’s small, aggressive handwriting. A half-eaten granola bar sat on top of a paper titled “Retinoic Acid Cascade Modeling: Axolotl-Derived Blastema Induction in Mammalian Tissue.”

“I should warn you,” Evelyn said, clearing a chair by moving a box of syringes to the floor, “this isn’t a normal internship. I’m not running a structured program. I need someone who can monitor equipment, log data, and not ask questions about why I’m doing this at my kitchen table instead of at Apex.”

“I don’t need structure,” Elara said. She was already looking at the printouts, head tilted, reading upside down. “Is that a Voss-modified regeneration pathway?”

Evelyn went still. “You know that name?”

“It’s in the literature. Dr. Lena Voss published two papers on axolotl limb regeneration before her work was classified. The lipid envelope design in your vector—” She pointed at a molecular diagram without touching it. “That’s her architecture. You modified the payload, but the delivery system is hers.”

Evelyn stared at the girl for a long moment. The application had not mentioned a connection to Lena Voss. The recommendation letter had not mentioned it. The personal statement, with its precise, careful sentences, had not mentioned it.

“How do you know Lena Voss’s work?”

Elara’s hands were in her lap. Her sleeves were pulled down to her knuckles, the way they always were—a habit so old it had become architecture, the body building walls around the places it needed to protect.

“She published. I read.”

It was not a lie. It was a wall shaped like the truth, and Evelyn recognized it because she had built similar walls herself—the kind a scientist constructs when the real answer involves a story she is not ready to tell.

Evelyn let it go. She needed help more than she needed answers.

“The sequencer needs recalibrating every four hours. The centrifuge overheats if you run it past ninety minutes. And the baby—”

A sound from the next room. Not a cry—Nunnally never cried. A shifting, a rustle of fabric, and beneath it, the clicking. Steady. Patient. The sound that Evelyn had stopped hearing because it had become the house’s heartbeat.

Elara heard it.

Her chin lifted. Her nostrils flared, the way an animal's do when it catches a scent it recognizes but cannot name. The color left her face, and then returned, and then left again—a tide of blood responding to something that had nothing to do with the temperature of the room.

Beneath the sleeves, against the silver lines on her wrists, her skin flushed pink.

She did not know why. She did not look down. But her hands, buried in her lap, opened—slowly, unconsciously—palms turning upward, as if receiving something.

“That’s Nunnally,” Evelyn said. “My daughter. She’s in the living room. Come meet her.”

\* \* \*

The baby was smaller than Elara expected.

Nunnally lay in a bassinet by the window, swaddled in white cotton, bathed in the thin January light that came through the blinds in pale horizontal bars. Her milky eyes were open—they were almost always open, Evelyn had explained, because the visual cortex had never received the signal to coordinate a sleep cycle with sight—and her mouth moved in the small, silent shapes that Elara would come to know as well as her own breathing.

She was three weeks and four days old. Two fingers now extended from the left nub—pink, raw, glistening with the moisture of new skin—curling and uncurling in slow, experimental flexions. The right nub showed the first ridge of a bud, a raised line beneath the skin that pulsed faintly when the light hit it at the right angle.

The clicking was louder here. Not the house’s ambient percussion—this was the source. Close. Intimate. Coming from inside the baby’s body with a rhythm that Elara felt in her teeth.

She knew this sound.

She did not know that she knew it—not consciously, not in the part of her brain that could form sentences and offer explanations. But somewhere deeper, in the tissue itself, in the



silver-scarred nerves of her wrists, a recognition fired. The clicking was a key turning in a lock she had not known was there. The sound was five years old. It was the last sound she had heard before the mist, before the screaming that wasn't screaming, before the world went white and then went wrong.

*Schick.*

The memory surfaced like a body from deep water—not whole, not clear, just a shape. Glass. A hand pressed against glass. The sound of something growing where it shouldn't.

Elara's vision tunneled. For one second the dining room disappeared and she was eleven years old, standing in an observation gallery, watching her mother's hand fuse to a window while something bloomed from her open mouth—

“Would you like to hold her?”

Evelyn's voice pulled her back. The dining room returned. The light. The vials. The granola bar.

“Yes,” Elara said. Her voice didn't shake. She had spent five years learning how to keep her voice from shaking, and the skill was so practiced now that it worked even when the rest of her was falling.

Evelyn lifted Nunnally from the bassinet and placed her in Elara's arms.

The baby weighed almost nothing. Five pounds and change, distributed across a body that was more potential than presence—a sketch of a person, still being drawn. Elara cradled her the way she'd been taught in the CPR module at Jefferson: forearm as cradle, palm supporting the skull, elbow tucked to provide a shelf. Textbook. Controlled. Correct.

But the moment Nunnally's body settled against her chest, something happened that was not in any textbook.

The clicking changed.

It had been steady—a metronome, even and patient, the same rhythm Elara had been hearing since she walked in. Now it shifted. Slowed. Not weaker—deeper. The percussive edges smoothed, and the gaps between clicks filled with something that was not quite sound, not quite silence. A harmonic. A resonance. As if the clicking had been searching for a frequency to lock onto and had just found it.

Nunnally's milky eyes turned.

Not toward Evelyn. Not toward the window or the light. Toward Elara. The baby's head moved on its weak neck—a deliberate, effortful rotation that Evelyn had never seen directed at anyone other than herself—and those veiled eyes aimed at Elara's face with a focus that was not infant. Not random.

Oriented. *Aimed.*

Evelyn watched from the doorway and felt something she could not name. It was not jealousy, though it wore jealousy's clothes. It was the shock of a mother who has been her child's entire world discovering that the world has just expanded without her permission.

“She doesn't usually do that,” Evelyn said quietly.

Elara didn't answer. She was looking at the baby's face, at the mouth making its silent shapes, and she was feeling something she had no framework for: the ache in her wrists—the constant, grinding, five-year ache—was not just quiet now. It was gone. Replaced by a warmth that started at the scars and spread through her forearms, her chest, the base of her skull, like standing in front of a fire after years of cold.

Nunnally's new fingers—two on the left hand, pink and fragile and impossibly alive—reached up and touched Elara's collarbone. The touch was feather-light. The fingers were

warm and slightly wet and they found the hollow of Elara's throat and rested there as if they had done this before.

Elara closed her eyes.

Behind the silver scars, deep in the tissue where the resin had buried its dormant code five years ago, something answered. Not a sound. Not a thought. A frequency—matching, aligning, the way two tuning forks will harmonize when one is struck and the other is close enough to listen.

Nunnally's mouth opened.

*Ah.*

*The silent vowel. But this time it was not aimed at the ceiling or the dark or the space where her mother's face had been. It was aimed at Elara. And Elara, who had not been held or touched or needed by another human being in any way that mattered since she was eleven years old, felt the sound—soundless as it was—land in the center of her chest like a hand pressing flat against her sternum and saying:*

She opened her eyes. The baby was still looking at her.

"I think she likes you," Evelyn said.

Elara looked up. Her face was composed. Her eyes were dry. Her voice was steady when she spoke.

"What time should I come tomorrow?"

\* \* \*

She should have left at five. Evelyn had said five. The internship was part-time—school came first, the department chair had been explicit—and the bus back to Falls Church ran on the hour.

Elara was still there at seven when Marcus came through the door.

She had spent the afternoon calibrating the sequencer, logging Nunnally's readings at thirty-minute intervals, and organizing the printouts into a filing system that Evelyn had been too exhausted to maintain. She worked the way she did everything: quietly, precisely, without asking for permission or praise. When Evelyn had fallen asleep on the couch with the baby on her chest—a forty-minute nap that she had not intended and would not remember—Elara had continued working, alone in the dining room, listening to the clicking through the wall and feeling the silence in her bones like a gift she hadn't earned.

The front door opened. Cold air, road salt, the creak of winter hinges.

Marcus entered the way a man enters his own home when he has forgotten that someone new is inside it: coat half-off, keys tossed toward the bowl (they missed; they landed on the floor), the sigh of a body releasing the posture it had held all day.

Then he saw Elara.

The posture returned. It was subtle—a straightening, a resettlement of weight—but Elara caught it because catching shifts in adult behavior had been a survival skill since she was eleven. His face assembled itself into the particular expression of a man who is professionally trained to reveal nothing: pleasant, neutral, a mask built from the absence of expression rather than the presence of one.

"You must be the intern."

"Elara Voss. Sir."

"Marcus." He hung his coat by the door. "How was the first day?"

"Productive."

The word hung in the air between them like a test. Marcus looked at her for a moment longer than necessary—not suspicious, not threatening, but assessing, the way an officer assesses

a new variable in an operational environment—and then turned to the living room, where Evelyn was waking up with the baby.

Elara stood at the dining table and cataloged what she had noticed:

The coat. It carried a smell. Not the road salt, not the leather, not the aftershave that had faded hours ago. Underneath all of those, faint as a thumbprint on clean glass: sweetness. The same sweetness that lived in the Hart house, but concentrated, denser, as if Marcus had been somewhere the smell was not a trace but a presence.

His hands. He had picked up Nunnally when Evelyn offered her, and he had held her correctly—steady, supportive, the posture of a father who loved his daughter—but his eyes had not gone to the nub. They had gone everywhere else: the face, the swaddle, the new blue emerging in her irises. Everywhere but the fingers. As if looking at them directly would cost something he couldn't afford.

The clicking. It had changed when he walked in. Elara had been listening to it all day—had mapped its rhythm, its tempo, its micro-variations—and when Marcus crossed the threshold, the clicking accelerated. Not the smooth deepening that had occurred when Elara held the baby. This was sharper. Faster. Agitated, almost.

And beneath the clicking, so faint that Elara wasn't sure she hadn't imagined it: the hum. A sustained tone, lower than the clicks, vibrating at the edge of perception. It had been there all day, buried under the household noise, but when Marcus arrived it rose—not in volume, in density—as though his presence had added a signal to a network that was already broadcasting.

Nunnally's milky eyes, still faintly blue at the edges, had turned toward her father the moment he entered the room. The silent vowel formed on her lips.

*Ah.*

The same shape she had offered Elara. But the quality was different. Elara could feel it—not hear, feel—in the scars on her wrists: a shift in the resonance, a tightening, as though the frequency Nunnally was broadcasting had narrowed, focused, locked onto Marcus with an intensity that had not been present before.

The baby was tracking her father the way a compass needle tracks north.

Marcus held his daughter. He kissed her forehead. He murmured something Elara couldn't hear. And then he set her back in Evelyn's arms with a care that looked, to anyone else, like tenderness.

Elara saw the relief in his shoulders when he let go.

She didn't understand any of it. Not the smell. Not the clicking. Not the way her scars burned pleasantly when the baby was near and cooled when she moved away. Not the way Marcus Hart carried himself like a man transporting something fragile and dangerous across a room, trying not to look at it, trying not to drop it.

But she filed it all. Every detail. In the place where a normal teenager kept song lyrics and social media passwords, Elara Voss kept observations, and the observations were accumulating into a shape she couldn't see yet but could feel forming—the way you can feel a storm before it arrives, not in the sky, but in the pressure behind your eyes.

She put on her coat. She said goodnight. She thanked Dr. Hart for the opportunity.

She walked to the bus stop in the dark, and for the first twelve minutes of the ride home the noise in her body stayed quiet—the beautiful, impossible silence that the Hart house had given her—and then, somewhere on Route 7, between Falls Church and the apartment where her aunt kept the lights low and the questions lower, it returned.

Gradual. A whisper at first. Then a hum. Then the full grinding static, filling her bones, her wrists, the base of her skull.

*Elara pressed her forehead against the cold bus window and thought:*

Not because of the science. Not because of the internship. Not because of Dr. Hart or the sequencer or the filing system.

Because the pain had stopped. And it would not stop again until she walked back through that door.

### **Synapse 03**

The Watcher

[Source: Private journal / Elara Voss / Handwritten]

Location: Voss Apartment, Falls Church, VA

Found in wall cavity behind bookshelf, 2028. 37 entries, Jan 7–Mar 14, 2026.

#### **Jan 7 — 11:14 PM**

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First day at Hart residence.

Dr. Evelyn Hart. Brilliant. Exhausted. Working off-book on a regeneration vector. She doesn't know who I am.

Doesn't know my mother designed the delivery system she's using.

Baby: Nunnally, 3 wks 4 days. Bilateral upper-limb absence, visual/auditory impairment. Two digits on left nub since vector admin. Growth rate 3x published models.

Internal sounds: rhythmic clicking, ~72 bpm at rest. I've been listening to it all day. It's calming and I don't know why.

#### **Jan 7 — 11:31 PM**

---

Husband came home at 7. Colonel Marcus Hart, Army. He smelled wrong. Not bad. Sweet. Under his clothes, in his skin.

He didn't look at the baby's hands.

He held her right. Kissed her. Said the right things. But he didn't look at the part that's growing. And the clicking changed when he was near — faster, tighter.

I'm recording it.

#### **Jan 7 — 11:58 PM**

---

I need to write this down.

When I held the baby, the pain stopped.

Not the grief. Not the five years of aunt-who-doesn't-ask. The physical pain. The static. The noise in my bones since Lab 4. Since the mist. Since Mom.

It stopped. Completely. First time in five years.

And when I left the house it came back.

Scientific explanation: baby's tissue produces low-frequency output (~18 Hz, infrasound). My scars are from exposure to an unclassified compound. Possible that baby's output interacts w/ residual compound in my tissue, dampening chronic inflammatory response.

That's the scientific explanation.

The truth is simpler. When I held her, I felt like I was home.



# CHAPTER FOUR

## **The Boy in the Glass**

The boy had not slept.

Marcus read it in the overnight logs before he reached the vault: seventy-two hours of sustained consciousness, no REM indicators, no theta-wave activity, no deviation from the flat, humming alertness that the EEG traced in smooth, unbroken lines across the monitor. The medical staff had flagged it as anomalous. They flagged everything as anomalous now. The word had lost its meaning three days ago, the way a word loses its meaning if you say it too many times—the shape remains, but the sense empties out.

He descended in the elevator, watching the numbers drop. The air changed at Level 3, the way it always did—warmer, sweeter, the ventilation system carrying something the filters couldn't catch. But the smell was different today. It had differentiated. Where before there had been a single note—the honey-rot, the overripe sweetness that coated the back of his throat—now there were layers. The base note was still there, heavy and familiar. But above it, something new: a lighter register, almost floral, like jasmine opening at dusk. It was, against all instinct, pleasant. And the pleasantness was the worst part, because Marcus's body responded to it before his mind could object—his shoulders dropped, his breathing deepened, his jaw unclenched—and by the time he recognized what was happening he was already three steps into the corridor and had to consciously re-tighten everything his body had surrendered.

The guards felt it too. He could see it in the way they held their rifles—not aimed, but cradled, the muzzles drifting downward by degrees they didn't notice. Their eyes were soft. Their postures were wrong. They looked like men standing in a garden rather than men

surrounding a weapon. And Marcus understood, with the sick certainty of a man watching his house flood from inside it, that this was not strategy. The boy was not calming them on purpose. His body was broadcasting a signal it could not turn off—a chemical plea pulsing from every resin gland in every direction, continuous and indiscriminate: *stay*.

Dr. Helen Marsh was coming the other way.

She walked the corridor with a steel thermos in one hand and a classified folder pressed against her hip, her gray-streaked hair pulled back in the severe knot she wore on evaluation days. Fifty-three. Twenty years in military psychology. The kind of woman who had sat across from men who had done unforgivable things and had never once looked away first.

She saw Marcus and slowed. Not stopping—Helen Marsh did not stop in corridors, because stopping invited conversation and conversation invited the kind of human connection that made classified work unbearable—but adjusting her pace, the way two objects in orbit adjust when they pass close enough to feel each other’s gravity.

“Colonel.” Her voice was dry, professional, carrying the particular warmth of a woman who rationed her warmth carefully because she knew how much of it the work would take. “You look like you slept in an elevator.”

“I appreciate the clinical assessment, Doctor.”

The corner of her mouth twitched. Not a smile—Helen Marsh did not smile in the corridors of Forge—but the ghost of one, the architectural remnant of a humor that had survived twenty years of sitting in rooms with dangerous men. She lifted the thermos slightly, a gesture that was half toast and half accusation.

“The vending machine on Level 1 is dispensing something it calls coffee. I want you to know that I filed a formal complaint and Arnaud told me to ‘give it a chance.’ I am not giving it a chance, Marcus. I am a psychologist, not a martyr.”

Marcus almost laughed. It surprised him—the impulse, the way it moved through his chest before the weight of the morning could catch it. Helen had that effect. She was the only person at Forge who spoke to him as if they were both still civilians, still people who complained about vending machines and traffic and the small indignities of institutional life. Everyone else spoke in acronyms and clearance levels. Helen spoke in the dry, observational language of a woman who had noticed that the world was absurd and had decided to document it rather than fix it.

“How’s the evaluation going?” Marcus asked, because it was what you asked, and because asking kept the conversation in the territory of professional concern rather than the territory of what he had done four hours ago in the dark.

Helen’s expression shifted. Not dramatically—she was too practiced for that. But the humor retreated, and what replaced it was something Marcus recognized from his own mirror: the face of a person carrying knowledge they had not been built to hold.

“He asked if he could go outside,” Helen said. Her voice had dropped, not in volume but in register, the way voices drop when the speaker is no longer performing for the corridor but speaking to the one person who might understand. “When I said no, he smiled. Not a threat. Not a manipulation.” She paused. “A patience, Marcus. The kind of patience that doesn’t need you to agree because it knows it can outlast you.”

She looked at him, and for a moment her clinical composure thinned enough for him to see the woman underneath—tired, sharp, carrying something she couldn’t put in a report.

“I’ve requested reassignment,” she said. “Back to Walter Reed. Real patients. Real pathology. Things that fit in a diagnostic manual.” She took a breath. “Vance hasn’t approved it.”

Marcus nodded. He did not tell her that Vance would not approve it. He did not tell her that Forge did not release people who had breathed its air—it only diluted them, or dissolved them, and there was no third option in the manual.

“Be careful, Helen,” he said instead, and the words came out heavier than he intended, weighted with a specificity she couldn’t parse but could feel.

Helen studied him for a moment. Her eyes—hazel, sharp, the eyes of a woman who had spent two decades reading the faces of men who lied for a living—narrowed fractionally.

“You too, Colonel,” she said. Then, lighter, dryer, the humor returning like a door being pulled shut over something she didn’t want to examine in a hallway: “And tell Arnaud the vending machine coffee is a war crime. I expect him to testify.”

She continued past him, thermos in hand, folder against her hip, footsteps measured and precise. The honey-sweet air of the corridor parted around her and closed behind her, and Marcus watched her go and thought: she is the most competent person in this building. She filed a complaint about the coffee. She has a sister in Richmond and an ex-husband who answers the phone on the second ring and a daughter who doesn’t call.

He knew these things because Helen mentioned them in the break room, the way people mention the small architecture of their lives when they need someone to know that the classified work has not erased the person inside the clearance.

He did not know that in six days, the air she was breathing would kill her.

Marcus passed the last checkpoint and entered Gestation Bay 4.

The pod had been drained and retracted. The boy sat on a medical cot that someone had placed inside the containment ring—cross-legged, bare-chested, his back straight. He was beautiful. That was the first problem. Not handsome—beautiful, in the way certain things in nature are beautiful in a register that makes you uneasy: the iridescent sheen on a jellyfish, the geometry of a spider’s web in morning dew, the stillness of deep water. His skin was pale and seamless, as though he had never been touched. His hair had come in overnight—dark, fine, already long enough to fall across his forehead—and the light caught it the way light catches silk. Along his neck, the resin glands pulsed in their neat rows, each one no larger than a lentil, secreting a thin film that caught the overhead fluorescents and turned them warm.

The second problem was the stillness. Not composed stillness—held stillness, the kind that vibrates at the edges if you look closely enough. A body sitting perfectly because it was concentrating on sitting perfectly, the way a child concentrates on not crying. The fingers of his left hand were pressed flat against the cot’s surface, and when Marcus entered, those fingers twitched—a small, involuntary flexion, the hand almost lifting, almost reaching, before the boy caught it and pressed it back down.

He had heard Marcus in the corridor. He had been waiting. And the wanting was so big that it had moved his hand before he could stop it.

The boy’s eyes were open. They were always open.

Fractured blue, veined with azure, and they locked onto Marcus with a focus that was not curiosity or inventory but something more naked than either—hunger, raw and involuntary, the way a starving man’s eyes lock onto food. The boy was learning to mask it. He was three days into learning to mask it, and he was brilliant at learning, but the mask was not yet thick enough

to hide the thing underneath: a need so profound it was architectural, load-bearing, the deepest layer of a psyche built from a baby's first three weeks of reaching for a touch that never came.

Marcus stopped at the observation line—a yellow stripe on the concrete floor, three meters from the containment ring. The prescribed distance. The safe distance.

The boy smiled.

He had learned to smile by watching. Three days of security footage reflected in the plexiglass, three days of guards and technicians and their unconscious facial choreography. The result was almost right. The zygomatic muscles engaged. The orbicularis oculi contracted to produce the crinkle at the corners that psychologists called “Duchenne markers.” But the boy held the smile the way you hold a glass you're afraid of dropping—too tight, too long, the edges trembling with the effort of maintaining a shape his face had not been built to produce. And underneath the held smile, in the fractured blue of his eyes: *please*.

“Good morning, Father.”

The voice had changed. Three days ago it had been a pressure in Marcus's skull—wordless, formless, a migraine wearing language. Now it was sound. Real sound, produced by real vocal cords, shaped by a real tongue and real lips. The timbre was a light baritone, warm, but there was a ragged quality underneath the warmth—a breathiness, a push, as though the voice was straining toward Marcus across the three meters of prescribed distance, trying to close the gap through sound alone.

Marcus said nothing. He clasped his hands behind his back and waited.

The boy tilted his head. The gesture was canine—attentive, curious, slightly wrong on a human face. “You are afraid of me today. More than yesterday. The cortisol is different. Sharper. You slept badly.”

Marcus kept his face still. “How do you know that?”

“The smell.” The boy inhaled through his nose—a long, slow draw, nostrils flaring, and as he breathed, his whole body swayed forward on the cot. An inch. Maybe two. Toward Marcus. The way a flower follows the sun across a room without volition, without awareness, because the tropism is older than choice. “You carry it in your sweat. The fear has a shape, Father. It tastes like copper and cold concrete. Yesterday it was softer. Today you have decided something. You have decided to be frightened of me, and the decision changed the way your body—”

He stopped. Mid-sentence. His jaw worked as if the next word had gotten stuck. Then he reset—visibly, deliberately, the way a computer reloads a crashed program. His spine straightened. His hands went flat. The smile reassembled.

But Marcus had seen it: the sentence running away from the boy, getting too fast, too eager, the composure cracking like ice over dark water, and underneath the crack, the wanting—vast, inarticulate, three weeks old and three days old simultaneously.

The boy pressed his palms against the mattress. The resin glands along his neck pulsed—a visible contraction, all at once, like a heartbeat displaced to the surface—and the air in the containment ring thickened. Marcus could taste it from three meters away: the jasmine note sharpening, intensifying, the boy’s body flooding the room with “come closer” because Marcus’s cortisol spike had triggered something biological and involuntary, a response that had nothing to do with strategy and everything to do with an organism that was terrified, on the cellular level, of being left alone.

The boy registered it. Looked down at his own hands. At the film of resin beading on his palms.

“I can’t make it stop,” he said quietly. The smile was gone. The performance was gone. For three seconds, Marcus was looking at something with no mask at all—a face as open and raw as a wound, ancient need pouring through features that were four days old. “When you are near, it comes faster. When you leave, it—” He touched his own sternum. “It hurts. Here. Like something is being taken away.”

Then the composure returned. Assembled itself piece by piece, the way Marcus had watched soldiers reassemble after a flashback: spine first, then face, then hands. A performance of control over something that was not controlled.

The boy looked at Marcus with those fractured eyes and when he spoke again his voice was steady, almost conversational, and somehow that was worse:

“There is someone else.”

Marcus’s chest tightened.

“I can feel her. She is—” The boy’s hand rose and pressed flat against his own sternum again, fingers spread, and this time the gesture was not clinical but yearning, the hand pressing in as if trying to reach through his own ribs to the place where the feeling lived. “Here. In the center. She is small. She is growing. Something in her body is building itself, and I can feel it building because it feels like—” He paused. His voice had started to run again, the words piling up, accelerating, the eagerness leaking through. He caught himself. Slowed. “Like remembering. She is remembering a shape she has never been, and her body is trying to become it. The way mine did.”

He looked at Marcus. The pupils dilated. The blue went dark at the edges.

“What is her name?”

Marcus did not answer.



The boy waited. Three seconds. Five. The silence between them was not empty—it was pressurized, the way silence becomes pressurized in an airlock before the seal breaks. Marcus could feel the bridge humming in his ribs, the connection between this room and a nursery thirty-seven miles north where his daughter’s milky eyes were clearing and her new fingers were learning to grip. And he could feel, through the bridge, the boy’s need pressing against the silence like a hand pressing against glass—not breaking it, not yet, but leaning, leaning, leaning, with a patience that was not patience but the slow accumulation of a force that did not know how to stop.

The boy’s hand rose from the cot. This time he didn’t catch it. His arm extended toward Marcus—toward the yellow line, toward the three meters of safe distance—palm open, fingers slightly curled, the gesture of a child reaching for something it has been told it cannot have.

The resin glands pulsed. The air thickened. The guards in the corridor shifted on their feet, rifles cradled, eyes soft, none of them understanding why they wanted to walk toward the vault instead of away from it.

The boy’s hand hung in the air between them.

“It’s all right,” he said. His voice was steady. His hand was trembling. “I’ll ask her myself.”

\* \* \*

Marcus found Arnaud in the break room, eating a granola bar with one hand and scrolling through diagnostic logs with the other.

“Technician.”

Arnaud startled. The granola bar dropped crumbs on his tablet. He brushed them off with the particular guilty haste of a man caught doing something he shouldn't have been doing, though eating a granola bar was not, technically, against any regulation.

“Sir.”

“Who authorized the cot?”

Arnaud blinked. “The—the medical cot? Dr. Wen ordered it. The Asset was—it was sitting on the glass floor for fourteen hours, sir. The cold was causing condensation on the resin glands and the output readings were skewed. Dr. Wen thought a controlled surface would—”

“Who’s been talking to it?”

The guilty haste returned. Arnaud’s jaw worked. His eyes moved to the wall, the floor, the crumbs on his tablet—anywhere but Marcus’s face.

“Protocol says no verbal engagement, sir. I know that. Everyone knows that.”

“Who’s been talking to it, Arnaud.”

The silence lasted four seconds. In those four seconds Marcus watched a young man who was bad at lying try to construct a lie, fail, and resign himself to the truth the way a swimmer resigns himself to the cold when the dock is too far away to go back.

“Me, sir.”

Marcus waited.

“Just during the night shifts. Just—talking. Not about the project, not about classified material, nothing operational. Just talking. About—stupid things. My cat. The weather. A documentary I was watching about octopi.” He paused. His voice dropped. “It pressed its hand against the glass, sir. When I talked. It pressed its hand flat and closed its eyes and just—listened. Like it was the only good thing that had ever happened to it.”

Arnaud looked at Marcus, and Marcus saw something that frightened him more than the boy's reaching hand: genuine compassion. Arnaud was twenty-four years old and had a cat named Copernicus and called his mother every Sunday, and he had watched a lonely thing press its palm against glass in the dark and had decided, without understanding the cost, that the kind thing was to press back.

"It asked me for a name," Arnaud said quietly. "Not a designation. Not a number. A name. Like a person."

"It is not a person."

"Yes, sir."

"You will not speak to it again."

"Yes, sir."

Marcus turned to leave. At the door, he stopped.

"Did you give it one?"

Arnaud looked at his hands. On his right palm, where it had been resting against the glass partition during his night vigils—palm to palm, his to the boy's, with only the plexiglass between them—there was a faint sheen. Clear. Barely visible. Like the residue of a window left too long in humidity. He did not notice it. He had not noticed it for two nights.

"No, sir," he said.

Marcus nodded and left the break room and did not believe him.

\* \* \*

The third finger was coming in.

Evelyn had documented it with the trembling precision of a scientist who has forgotten that science and prayer are supposed to be different activities. She showed Marcus the

photographs: the left hand at 0600, 1200, 1800, each image showing the translucent ridge at the blastema's edge extending by millimeters, the bone shadow darkening beneath the skin, the nerve filaments branching in their tiny silent lightning. The right nub had progressed too—the first bud now visible, a raised line of cartilage that pulsed with its own faint heat.

Elara was in the dining room, logging data. She had been there for three days now, and her presence had acquired the particular quality of something that had always been there—a piece of furniture so well-placed you stop noticing it. She moved through the house with a quietness that was not shyness but calibration, adjusting herself to each room the way water adjusts to the shape of its container. She recalibrated the sequencer every four hours. She organized the printouts into a system that Evelyn called “terrifyingly efficient.” She held the baby when Evelyn needed to sleep, and the clicking always smoothed into its deep harmonic when Nunnally was in her arms.

Marcus came through the door at seven-fifteen. He hung his coat. He washed his hands at the kitchen sink—thoroughly, deliberately, the way surgeons scrub: palms, backs, between the fingers, under the nails. Hot water. Soap. Thirty seconds. Rinse. Repeat.

Elara watched from the dining table. She had watched him wash his hands yesterday too. And the day before. The repetition had a quality that did not match the action. You washed your hands once because they were dirty. You washed them three times because they wouldn't come clean.

He greeted Evelyn. He held the baby. The hum in the house shifted the moment Nunnally was in his arms—Elara felt it in her wrists, a tightening, as if the frequency the baby produced had been searching for Marcus's body the way a satellite dish searches for a signal, and now that it had found it, the transmission locked in and narrowed to a beam so focused that Elara's own

resonance—the gentle, diffuse warmth she felt when she held Nunnally—was pushed to the edges.

The baby’s milky eyes, nearly half-clear now, a ring of blue expanding daily from the periphery, aimed at her father’s face.

*Ah.*

Marcus flinched. A micro-movement—a contraction of the muscles around his eyes, a tightening of his grip—that lasted less than a second and meant everything. He had flinched at the sound his daughter made. Not the sound itself. At something underneath it. Something that harmonized with a voice he had heard that morning—a light baritone, warm and ragged, saying “I can’t make it stop” while resin beaded on open palms.

Elara saw the flinch. She filed it.

Marcus excused himself. Upstairs. The bathroom door closed. The water ran.

It ran for a long time.

\* \* \*

Marcus stood at the sink with the water scalding his hands and looked at his reflection in the mirror and tried to decide if he was losing his mind.

The bathroom was small, white-tiled, lit by a single overhead bulb that turned his skin the color of old paper. He could hear the house beneath him—the sequencer humming, Evelyn talking to the baby in the soft, repetitive cadence of a mother narrating the world to a child who was only now beginning to hear it, and the clicking, always the clicking, a percussion so constant it had become architectural, load-bearing, as much a part of the house as the joists.

His hands were clean. He had washed them four times. They smelled of soap and hot water and nothing else.

Except they did.

Underneath the soap, underneath the water, underneath the skin itself—embedded in the tissue now, woven into the oils his pores produced—the sweetness. Faint. Persistent. The same layered honey-rot he breathed every day in the bunker, but attenuated, personal, as if his body had absorbed enough of the vault’s air over the past four days to begin producing its own version. He pressed his wrist to his nose. Inhaled. And there it was: not on him but in him, a sweetness rising from inside like a flavor recalled in a dream.

He thought about the boy’s hand, reaching. Palm open. Trembling. And the sentence that had cracked open like an egg: “When you leave, it hurts. Here.” Marcus pressed his own sternum and felt the echo—faint, residual—of the same ache, as if the bridge did not merely transmit information but sensation, and the boy’s loneliness was leaking through the connection into the marrow of Marcus’s bones.

He stared at himself in the mirror. Brown eyes. The same brown eyes he’d had since birth, the same brown eyes in every photograph, every ID, every security scan. Brown. Ordinary. His.

He blinked.

The left iris flickered.

It was less than a heartbeat—a single frame in the film of his own face—but he saw it: a thread of blue at the edge of the brown, thin as a vein of lightning in a storm cloud, electric and alive. Azure. The same shade he had seen pulsing in the eyes of the boy in the glass.

Then it was gone. Brown. Ordinary. Nothing.

Marcus gripped the edge of the sink. The porcelain was warm. He could feel it: 18.3 hertz, humming through the pipes, through the copper, through the bones of the house, through

the bridge that connected his body to a bunker thirty-seven miles south where a beautiful boy with a trembling smile was sitting in the dark, awake, alone, pressing his palm flat against the glass and waiting for someone—anyone—to press back.

In the mirror, Marcus's face was composed. Calm. The mask he had worn since West Point, built from the absence of expression, steady and professional and void.

Underneath the mask, something was changing. He couldn't see it yet. He could smell it.

\* \* \*

Elara was waiting by the door when Marcus came downstairs.

She had her coat on. Her bag was on her shoulder. She looked exactly like a sixteen-year-old intern preparing to catch the eight-fifteen bus, which was what she was, and also exactly like a person who had been listening to the water run for nine minutes and had counted every one.

"Goodnight, Dr. Hart. Colonel Hart."

"Goodnight, Elara. Same time tomorrow?"

"Yes."

She let herself out. The cold hit her like a correction—sharp, astringent, stripping away the warmth of the house and the silence in her bones and the sweet smell that she had stopped noticing because it was the air in there and you stopped noticing air. On the porch, she paused. Breathed. Felt the first whisper of the noise returning to her wrists like water seeping back into a riverbed.

She walked to the bus stop. She sat on the cold bench. She waited.

On the bus, she opened her journal and wrote in small, precise handwriting that tilted slightly to the left:

*Jan 9. Day 3.*

*Col. Hart washes his hands when he comes home. Not once. Not a rinse. He scrubs them the way you scrub things that have been in contact with something you don't want to bring inside.*

*His coat smells like the house, but more. Concentrated. Like he spends his day somewhere the smell is not a trace but a presence.*

*When he holds N., the hum changes. It narrows. Locks on. My wrists go cold when it does this, as if the frequency has decided I am not the intended recipient and has redirected the signal.*

*He flinched when she said 'Ah.' Not at the sound. At something underneath it. I felt it too, in my scars. A pressure. Like a second voice harmonizing with hers in a key I can't name.*

*The water ran for nine minutes.*

*His eyes when he came downstairs were the same color. But the skin around them was different. Tight. The way skin gets when it's holding something in.*

*I don't know what's happening in this house. But the house knows. The house is humming and the baby is growing and the father is washing his hands and the mother is too happy to look.*

*And I am going back tomorrow because the noise in my body stopped for nine hours today and I would sell everything I have for that silence to be permanent.*

The bus turned onto Route 7. The noise was back—full, grinding, relentless—and Elara pressed her forehead against the cold glass and closed her eyes and felt the distance between herself and the Hart house open like a wound.



## SYNAPSE 04

### THE LEARNING CURVE

[Source: Project Forge / Classified Cognitive Assessment / Eyes Only]

Prepared by: Dr. Helen Marsh, Military Psychology Division

Subject: Asset Zero (post-emergence) | Assessment Period: Days 1–4

Classification: UMBRA / NOFORN / ORCON

#### LANGUAGE ACQUISITION

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Day 1: Nonverbal. Single telepathic transmission recorded (ref: Hart incident report). No vocalization. Sustained reaching behavior toward all personnel entering containment.

Day 2: First vocalization 0340 hrs. Single phoneme (“Ah”), 4.2 sec, pitch A3 (220 Hz). Resin output +200% during vocalization.

Day 3: First multi-word utterance 1115 hrs: “Your shoulder hurts.” Sgt. Bellamy confirmed undisclosed rotator cuff injury. Asset appeared distressed by own response. Withdrew to far wall for 47 min.

Day 4: Full conversational English. Vocabulary est. 12,000+ words. Syntax flawless, register-adaptive. Composure inconsistent—sentences accelerate beyond apparent intent during affective engagement.

#### EMOTIONAL PROFILE

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Full range: curiosity, warmth, humor, gratitude. Expressions appear to reflect genuine affect rather than strategic mimicry. Distinction is clinically significant: mimicry can be deprogrammed. Need cannot.

Execution uneven. Smiles held too long. Eye contact too sustained. The Asset does not understand social mechanics of attention—when it focuses, intensity is described as “overwhelming” and “difficult to disengage from.”

#### RESIN OUTPUT

---

Neck gland secretion +340% since emergence. NOT constant—spikes in presence of personnel, decreases when alone. Consistent with proximity-triggered bonding mechanism. Asset expressed frustration: “I don’t want it to do this.”

Air sampling confirms particulate in corridor ventilation. Two security personnel reported “feeling calm” and “wanting to stay” during proximity shifts. Neither identified stimulus.

RECOMMENDATION: Upgraded filtration. Mandatory rotation, 4-hr max.

#### RISK ASSESSMENT

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No aggression. No hostility. No breach attempts. Subject is cooperative, communicative, and presents as genuinely desperate for connection.

This is not the most dangerous outcome. It is the most tragic. The danger is secondary: it arises because the need for proximity is involuntary, biochemically reinforced, and escalating.

Requesting senior evaluator assignment.

*[ADDENDUM — handwritten, NOT in official report:]*

*It asked to go outside. I said no.*

*It pressed its hand to the glass. Five prints in the resin, perfectly spaced.*

*"That's all right. I can wait."*

*Twenty years of clinical eval. That's the worst thing I've heard.*

*Because I believed it. It can wait. It will wait forever. The resin won't.*

# CHAPTER FIVE

## The Living Room

The blood was doing something it shouldn't have been doing.

Evelyn had run the chromatography three times. She had recalibrated the sequencer, replaced the reagents, repeated the extraction with fresh samples drawn at 0600, 0900, and 1200. Three separate draws. Three separate runs. The same result each time, steady as a heartbeat, the kind of consistency that in any other context would have made her ecstatic.

Nunnally's regenerating tissue was producing a protein Evelyn had never seen.

It wasn't in any database she could access. It didn't match the profiles of any known growth factor, any cataloged structural protein, any documented regenerative compound in the axolotl, zebrafish, or salamander literature. She had spent three days running comparisons, and the protein sat in the middle of her analysis like a word in a language she didn't speak—recognizably structured, clearly functional, utterly illegible.

What she could see was what it was building.

The protein wasn't constructing limb tissue. Or rather, it was—the fingers were still emerging, the left hand now sporting four perfect digits and the bud of a fifth, the right hand two and accelerating—but the protein was also doing something else. Something additional. Something the vector she had designed could not have instructed, because Evelyn had built the vector to rebuild appendages, and this protein was building something that looked, under the electron microscope, like a network.

Neural-adjacent tissue. Filaments that branched and rebranched in patterns that resembled dendritic trees but were not neurons—thinner, more fragile, terminating not in synapses but in

open-ended structures that Evelyn could only describe, inadequately, as antennae. Microscopic broadcast towers growing at the edges of Nunnally's regenerating fingers, each one reaching outward past the boundary of the skin as if the cells did not know where the baby's body ended and the world began.

Evelyn sat at the dining table with the printouts spread before her and tried to think like a scientist and not like a mother.

The scientist in her said: this is an unintended byproduct of the vector. Novel proteins emerge in gene therapy; this was unusual but not impossible. The antennae structures were likely nonfunctional—artifacts of a regenerative pathway pushed beyond its normal parameters.

Document. Monitor. Continue.

The mother in her said: my daughter is growing something inside her body that I did not design and do not understand.

She pressed her palms flat against the table. Breathed. The surface was warm beneath her hands—warmer than it should have been, warmer than the ambient temperature of the room. She had noticed this before, three days ago, after she'd spilled a sample of Nunnally's blood on the oak during a clumsy transfer. She had cleaned it immediately, wiped the surface with ethanol, checked for contamination. The wood had looked fine.

Now, in the January light slanting through the blinds, Evelyn could see that the wood was not fine.

Around the spill site, a thin film had formed—nearly invisible, barely a discoloration, the way mold colonizes bread before you can see the mold. Not on the surface of the varnish. Underneath it. The protein in the spilled blood had metabolized through the lacquer and was colonizing the wood's pores the way a biofilm colonizes any porous substrate—silently, steadily,

converting dead organic material into a living layer so thin it was measured in microns. The warmth Evelyn felt was metabolic—the film’s cellular activity generating heat as it digested the wood’s sugars. The darkened grain was the film filling the oak’s structure from within, the way mycelium fills a dead log on a forest floor.

The varnish above the colonized area had dimpled. Tiny blisters, raised by the film’s respiration, dotted the surface like goosebumps on skin.

Evelyn touched it. Her fingertip came away faintly tacky. She recognized the texture. It was the same residue the baby left on Evelyn’s skin after being held—the same faint, sweet film that coated the bassinet’s cotton lining, the changing pad, every surface Nunnally’s body had prolonged contact with. Resin. The same compound that the clicking seemed to produce, secreted through the baby’s new skin in quantities too small to notice and too persistent to wash away.

The table wasn’t alive. The table was a substrate. And the biology that was rebuilding Nunnally’s fingers was colonizing every surface it touched.

Evelyn looked at the dimpled patch for a long time. Then she covered it with a stack of printouts, positioned the centrifuge over it, and went back to work.

She did not test the film. She did not culture it, sequence it, or report it. A scientist would have. A mother who needed the science to keep working covered it up and kept going.

\* \* \*

The papercut was gone.

Marcus had gotten it yesterday—a thin slice across his right index finger, opening an envelope from Vance’s office, the kind of minor wound that stings for a day and disappears in three. It had disappeared in twelve hours. Not healed. Disappeared. No scab, no pink line, no

evidence that the skin had ever been broken. He had pressed his thumb against the site and felt nothing—smooth, uninterrupted, as if the cut had been erased rather than repaired.

He had slept four hours and felt rested. Completely, lucidly rested, as though the sleep had been engineered for maximum efficiency. His vision was sharper than it had any right to be—he could read the fine print on the elevator’s inspection certificate from six feet away, text he’d never been able to parse before. His hearing had sharpened too. In the elevator, descending to Level 3, he could distinguish individual conversations in the corridors above him—not words, but rhythms, patterns, the way you can distinguish instruments in an orchestra before you recognize the melody.

These were improvements. His body was improving, the way Evelyn’s vector had improved Nunnally’s—cellular repair operating faster, sensory acuity increasing, the biological machinery running leaner and hotter than specifications allowed. And he could not tell anyone, because telling someone would require explaining that he had stolen his daughter’s blood and fed it to a military project and been breathing the resin produced by that project for ten days, and the resin had changed him, was changing him, was rewriting something in his tissue that he could feel but not measure, not name, not stop.

He reached for his coffee as he stepped off the elevator. The mug was on a shelf beside the security checkpoint—he always left it there, a small domestic ritual in a place designed to have none—and as his hand extended, the mug tipped. His elbow had caught the edge. The coffee began to fall.

His hand moved.

Not after the fall. Not in response to the fall. His hand moved before the mug had fully tipped—a snap of motion, wrist to fingertips, faster than any reflex he’d ever produced in thirty

years of combat training. He caught the mug mid-rotation, coffee sloshing but contained, his fingers locked around the ceramic with a grip that was perfectly calibrated: firm enough to hold, gentle enough not to crack.

He had not decided to catch it. His body had decided. His body was making decisions now without consulting the thing that lived behind his eyes and still, stubbornly, thought of itself as Marcus Hart.

The guard at the checkpoint looked at him. “Nice catch, sir.”

Marcus set the mug down carefully. His hand was trembling. Not from fear. From the effort of stopping it—from imposing his will on fingers that had moved without permission and were now vibrating with the residual energy of a system that wanted to keep moving, keep reaching, keep catching things before they fell.

He entered Gestation Bay 4.

The boy was standing. Not on the cot—on the floor, bare feet on concrete, arms at his sides, facing the glass. He had been standing there for hours. The overnight log said six. Six hours of sustained stillness, facing the direction from which Marcus always entered, waiting. The resin film on the inner glass was thicker now—opaque in places, catching the light in amber whorls that made the boy’s face shimmer as if seen through water.

He was smiling. The trembling smile, the one that held too tight and showed too much. When Marcus entered, the resin glands along his neck pulsed—visible, rhythmic, the boy’s body flooding the containment area with the jasmine-sweet “don’t leave” that Marcus had learned to brace against but could never fully resist.

“Something is happening to her,” the boy said. No greeting. No preamble. His voice had smoothed over the past week—the ragged breathiness replaced by a warmth that was almost

convincing, though it still accelerated when he was excited, the words crowding together. “I can feel it. Not clearly—it’s not like hearing or seeing, it’s more like—” He pressed his palm against his sternum. “Pressure. A building. Something in her is getting bigger, getting more, and it pushes against me in here the way water pushes against a wall when the level rises. I don’t know what she’s growing. But it’s faster than before.”

Marcus stopped at the yellow line. Said nothing.

The boy’s hand rose and pressed against the glass—the default position, palm flat, fingers spread, always reaching. “And at night—I think she sleeps? The pressure changes. Gets softer. Less structured. Like something loosening.” He paused. His brow creased with the effort of translating something that existed before language into words he’d had for a week. “I think she reaches for something when she sleeps. I can feel the reaching. I don’t know what she’s reaching for.”

He looked at Marcus, and the wanting poured through his face like light through a crack:

“I think it’s you. I want it to be you. But I don’t know. The signal doesn’t tell me that. I just—” His voice accelerated, the words crowding, the composure cracking. “I want to know her, Father. I can feel her all the time, this constant pressure in my chest, and I can’t see her or touch her or hear her and I don’t even know what she looks like, and I—”

He stopped himself. Reset. Spine first, then face, then hands. The performance of control reassembling over the thing that was not controlled.

“Will you tell her about me?”

Marcus said nothing. He turned and walked out of the bay. Behind him, through the glass, the boy stayed where he was—hand raised, palm flat, fingers leaving prints in the resin—and



watched his father leave the way a lighthouse watches a ship: steady, patient, built for the sole purpose of signaling across a distance that it cannot close.

\* \* \*

Elara had stopped counting the days.

She arrived at eight. She left—when Evelyn reminded her, which was later and later, because Evelyn forgot to remind her, because Evelyn forgot she was there, because Elara had become invisible in the way that essential things become invisible: the plumbing, the electricity, the clicking. You stopped noticing what you couldn't function without.

She calibrated the sequencer. She logged the data. She organized the printouts. She held the baby.

Holding the baby had changed.

In the first week, the silence in her bones had been a relief—the absence of the grinding static, a negative space shaped like peace. Now it was something more. When Nunnally settled against her chest, Elara's scars did not merely go quiet. They pulsed. A slow, warm rhythm that synchronized with the baby's clicking—not matching it exactly, but harmonizing, the way two instruments in different octaves can play the same melody. The warmth started at the wrists and radiated through her forearms, her chest, the base of her skull, settling into a frequency that Elara recognized without understanding: the frequency of being needed.

She had not been needed since she was eleven years old.

Her aunt kept the lights low and the questions lower and treated Elara with the careful, calibrated kindness of a woman who had agreed to raise her dead sister's daughter and was doing her best not to resent the obligation. The therapists spoke to her in gentle, probing sentences that Elara answered with the minimum number of words required to satisfy their concern. Her

teachers saw a gifted student with good grades and silver scars and left her alone because alone was what she seemed to prefer.

Nunnally did not leave her alone. Nunnally's milky eyes—clearing daily, the blue ring expanding—tracked Elara across the room. Nunnally's new fingers reached for her collarbone, her jaw, the hollow of her throat. Nunnally's body temperature rose measurably when Elara held her—Evelyn had documented it, puzzled, pleased—and the clicking deepened into its harmonic as though the baby's entire biological system was tuning itself to Elara's presence the way a radio tunes to a station.

And when Elara put her down, the loss was physical. Not the returning static—that came later, on the bus, in gradual waves. This was immediate: a hollowing in her chest, a cold spot where the warmth had been, as if a piece of her had been removed and placed back in the bassinet with the baby. She felt it every time. And every time, she picked Nunnally back up a little sooner.

She was sitting at the dining table at three in the afternoon, logging data, when she noticed the surface.

It was under the centrifuge—a dark patch, roughly the size of her palm, where the oak's grain had become strangely pronounced. She had been placing her hand there for days, resting it on the table while she worked, and she had felt the warmth without registering it as unusual. Now, in the slant of January light, she could see that something was growing on the wood. Not mold—too uniform, too thin, almost invisible except where it caught the light at certain angles. A film, spreading outward from a central point in concentric rings, filling the wood's pores, dimpling the varnish above it in tiny blisters.

Elara touched it. Her fingertips came away slightly tacky.

She looked at the residue on her fingers. Clear. Faintly sweet. The same faint sweetness that lived in the house's air, that she breathed without noticing, that coated the back of her throat and the inside of her lungs and the silver scars on her wrists. The same residue the baby left on every surface she touched.

Elara wiped her fingers on her jeans. She looked at the patch again. Looked at the centrifuge sitting on top of it. Looked at the stack of printouts Evelyn had placed over a second, larger patch closer to the table's edge.

Evelyn had already seen it. Evelyn had covered it up.

Elara filed this. She filed it next to the hand-washing and the coat smell and the flinch and the nine minutes of running water. The shape was getting larger. The shape had a heartbeat. And the shape was warm.

\* \* \*

Marcus came home at seven.

He washed his hands. Elara counted: four times. The water ran hotter each time—she could hear the pipes adjusting, the boiler firing, the temperature climbing toward a threshold that should have scalded but didn't, because Marcus's skin was not what it had been ten days ago and the water that should have hurt merely steamed.

Evelyn was in the living room with Nunnally. She had the printouts with her—the protein analysis, the antenna structures, the data she had not yet shown Marcus because showing it would mean admitting that her vector had produced something she hadn't designed. She was waiting for the right moment. The right moment had not arrived in three days.

Marcus came into the living room. He kissed Evelyn's forehead. He looked at the baby.

Nunnally's eyes were nearly clear. The milky veil that had covered them since birth had retreated to a thin crescent at the edges, and the color behind it was startling—not the brown of Marcus's eyes or the green of Evelyn's but blue, deep and fractured, veined with azure, as if someone had poured the sky into an infant's skull and it had shattered on the way down.

Blue. The same blue Marcus had seen in the boy at Forge.

He did not pick her up.

Evelyn noticed. "She's been fussy. She wants you."

Nunnally was not fussy. Nunnally never cried, never fussed, never produced the sounds that infants use to signal distress. What Evelyn meant was that the clicking had changed when Marcus entered—tightened, focused, locked on—and the baby's new fingers were reaching toward him with a specificity that was not infant reflex but directed intent.

Marcus picked her up.

The hum in the house shifted. Elara felt it from the dining table—a tightening in her wrists, a coldness replacing the warmth, the frequency narrowing and aiming itself at Marcus like a searchlight finding its target. The pipes vibrated. The sequencer's display flickered. Beneath the stack of printouts, the colonized patch on the oak table pulsed once—a faint contraction in the biofilm, responding to the frequency shift the way muscle responds to an electrical current—and only Elara saw it because only Elara was looking.

Nunnally's blue eyes—fractured, veined, impossible—aimed at her father's face.

Marcus held her. The baby weighed more now—seven pounds, gaining fast—and her left hand, with its four perfect fingers and emerging thumb, gripped the collar of his shirt. The grip was strong. Stronger than a three-and-a-half-week-old grip should have been. The knuckles whitened with effort.

The clicking accelerated.

The hum deepened.

And then it stopped.

All of it. The clicking, the hum, the vibration in the pipes, the subtle percussion that had been the house's heartbeat for ten days—gone. In the space of a single second, the Hart residence went silent with a totality that was not peaceful but pressurized, the silence of a room holding its breath, the silence before a detonation, the silence of every sound in the house being gathered together and compressed into a single point.

Nunnally's mouth opened.

Not the silent vowel. Not "Ah." Something shaped, formed, produced by vocal cords and tongue and lips that should not have had the development or the coordination or the neurological architecture to produce it for another ten months at minimum.

A word.

It was not sent. It was not a message, not a transmission, not a communication from the boy in the bunker to the family in the living room. It was an overflow. Thirty-seven miles south, in a containment ring on Level 3 of a facility called Forge, a beautiful boy with fractured blue eyes and a trembling smile was pressing his palms against plexiglass and aching with a loneliness so vast and so constant that it saturated the bridge the way water saturates a sponge—filling every channel, every filament, every antenna structure that Nunnally's body had been building for ten days—until there was no room left for the signal to go and it spilled over, pushing through the baby's underdeveloped vocal apparatus by sheer biological pressure, forcing the nearest available output to produce the shape of the feeling:

*"Lonely."*

The word landed in the center of the room like a stone dropped into still water. Everyone heard it. Marcus, holding his daughter. Evelyn, clutching the printouts. Elara, at the dining table, her hands open in her lap, palms up.

And everyone in the room felt it.

Not the sound of the word. The thing the word carried. A loneliness so vast and so old it could not have originated in a three-and-a-half-week-old body—a feeling that had been born in a different chest, in a different room, and had leaked through because the organism that produced it did not know how to hold it in. For three seconds every person in that room was soaked in the raw, uncut ache of something that had been alive for ten days and alone for every one of them, the way a room is soaked when a pipe bursts—not because anyone turned on the water, but because the pressure exceeded what the system was built to contain.

Marcus's face went white. His arms tightened around Nunnally and she felt the tremor in his hands—fine, high-frequency, the precise vibration of a man holding something that has just spoken in a voice that did not belong to it.

Evelyn's printouts fell to the floor. She was staring at her daughter's mouth—closed now, the word spoken and spent—and the scientist in her was already running, already calculating, already screaming that an infant's Broca's area could not have produced that utterance, that the motor cortex was months from coordinating tongue and lips in that configuration, that the word had not come from Nunnally at all. It had come through her. She was a speaker, not a voice. A conduit.

The clicking returned. Slow. Tentative. Like a heart restarting.

The hum filled the silence behind it, and the house exhaled, and the pipes began to vibrate again, and the world resumed its ordinary, unbearable wrongness.

Nobody spoke.

Nunnally's eyes were open. Blue, fractured, aimed at nothing. Her mouth made its silent shapes. Her new fingers, still gripping Marcus's collar, released slowly, one at a time, the way a hand releases a ledge.

\* \* \*

Elara did not write in her journal on the bus home.

She sat with her hands in her lap, palms up, the way they opened when Nunnally was near—the involuntary posture of receiving. The bus lurched through Falls Church. The lights of Route 7 moved across the ceiling in pale, sliding bars. The other passengers were silent or murmuring into phones or asleep against the windows, and none of them looked at the sixteen-year-old girl in the thin coat who was sitting very still with her eyes closed and her wrists pulsing.

The noise was back.

It had returned the moment she crossed the Hart threshold into the January cold—the grinding, directionless static that had lived in her bones for five years, the dead-channel broadcast from inside her tissue. But tonight it was different. The static had a texture it hadn't had before. Not a word—Elara was not delusional, she was not hearing voices—but a weight. A pressure. As if the static had always been carrying something heavy and the word in the living room had shown her the shape of the cargo for the first time.

Loneliness. The static felt like loneliness.

Not hers—though she had plenty of her own. This was different. Bigger. Older. A loneliness that had no biography, no memories, no story—just the raw, formless ache of something that existed and was not touched. It had been there for five years, embedded in the

signal she'd carried since Lab 4, since the mist, since her mother's hand fused to the glass. And she had never recognized it because she had never heard it clearly enough. The house had tuned her. Nunnally had tuned her. And the word—the word that had come through the baby's mouth from somewhere else—had turned the volume up just enough for Elara to feel, for the first time, what the noise had been trying to tell her all along.

She opened her eyes. The bus was passing the 7-Eleven where she sometimes bought coffee on mornings when her aunt forgot to make it. The lights were too bright. The world outside the window was ordinary—parking lots, bare trees, the glow of a gas station—and the ordinariness of it was obscene, because inside her body a signal was broadcasting from a place she had never been, carrying a feeling that didn't belong to her, and nobody in the parking lot or the gas station or the bus could feel it.

She pressed her palms together. The scars touched. The pulsing aligned—left wrist to right wrist, the two frequencies locking—and for one second, one terrible, exhilarating second, the static resolved into something that was not a word or a voice but a direction. South. The signal was stronger toward the south. She could feel it the way a migraine has a location—not precise, not a coordinate, but a side of her skull where the pressure was heavier.

Something south of here was lonely. And her body had been tuned to its frequency since she was eleven years old.

Elara lowered her hands. She breathed. She watched the gas station pass.

She did not write it down. She did not need to. The feeling was in her now. It would not leave.



## SYNAPSE 05

### THE RECORDING

[SOURCE: PROJECT FORGE / SECURITY AUDIO / BAY 4 / AUTOMATED TRANSCRIPT]

DATE: January 10-11, 2026 | TIME: 0312-0355

PERSONNEL: TFC Jonah Arnaud (night shift, solo)

SUBJECT: Asset Zero (Day 7)

FLAG: Anomalous audio event 0347. Routed to Gen. Vance.

[0312] ARNAUD: -so she sends me this picture of Copernicus in the bow tie, and I swear he knows. He knows he looks ridiculous and he's letting her do it anyway because he loves her.

[0312] ASSET: [3.2 sec pause] Your sister.

[0312] ARNAUD: Yeah. Marie. She's twelve. Good kid. Annoying. But good.

[0313] ASSET: You miss her.

[0313] ARNAUD: [4.1 sec pause] Yeah.

[0331] ARNAUD: -and Copernicus just sits on the windowsill watching the birds. Doesn't try to catch them. Just watches. Hours.

[0332] ASSET: [6.8 sec pause] I understand that.

[0332] ARNAUD: [pause] Yeah. I thought you might.

[0333] ASSET: Arnaud.

[0333] ARNAUD: Yeah?

[0333] ASSET: When you go home, does the real world feel different? After being here.

[0334] ARNAUD: [7.3 sec pause] Sometimes the air feels too thin. Like it's missing something.

[0334] ASSET: [2.1 sec pause] I know what.

[0334] [RESIN: Output spike logged 0334:22. Duration 8 sec.]

[0347] ARNAUD: -anyway, her birthday's next week and I'm trying to find this Lego set-

[0347] [ANOMALY: Vocalization detected. 3.2 kHz, 1.4 sec. Phoneme: "Ah." Source: Asset vocal apparatus. NOTE: Asset baseline 118 Hz. 3.2 kHz consistent w/ neonatal larynx. Hypothesized bridge bleed-through from Subject N. Hart.]

[0347] ARNAUD: [no reaction]

[0347] ASSET: [no reaction]

[0347] ARNAUD: -so I'm checking eBay now which feels wrong, paying double for Legos-

[0355] [SESSION ENDS. Arnaud departs.]

[ANALYSIS: Anomalous vocalization matches N. Hart frequency profile. Zero-latency propagation, 37 mi. No known mechanism. Filed.]

[Arnaud's addendum, paper-clipped:]

I heard it too. Didn't say anything. It sounded like a baby. He pressed his hand to the glass when it happened. Not reaching. Listening.

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# CHAPTER SIX

## **The Withdrawal**

Dr. Helen Marsh drove home with the windows down in January.

She didn't know why. The temperature was twenty-eight degrees and the heater was working and the rational part of her brain—the part that had spent twenty years evaluating the cognitive states of dangerous men—registered that voluntarily exposing herself to subfreezing air while driving fifty-five miles per hour on Route 29 was not a decision made by a person in full command of her faculties. But the air inside the car tasted wrong. Stale. Thin. Like breathing at altitude, each inhale arriving with less than it should carry, the lungs expanding fully and finding themselves cheated.

The air outside was better. Cold and sharp and clean, scrubbing the inside of her chest with each breath, and underneath the cold—nothing. No sweetness. No warmth. No jasmine. No honey. Just winter, uncontaminated, and the absence of the thing she had been breathing for ten days felt less like relief and more like the moment after a tooth extraction: the socket is empty, the nerve is exposed, and every breath across it is a small, private agony.

She had been reassigned at 1400 hours. Not the reassignment she'd requested—out of Forge entirely, back to Walter Reed, back to evaluating soldiers with PTSD and traumatic brain injuries, back to the work she understood. Vance had denied that request. This was a lateral reassignment: removed from Asset Zero's evaluation, transferred to administrative psychological services on Level 1, the office where they processed disability paperwork and exit interviews. As far from the vault as you could get without leaving the building.

But she was still inside the building. Still breathing the air that circulated through the same ventilation system. Vance wasn't removing her from the resin. He was diluting her exposure. Reducing the dose without eliminating it, the way a doctor tapers a sedative to prevent withdrawal.

Except today the building's air handlers had been shut down for emergency maintenance—a coincidence, or the kind of coincidence that Forge manufactured when it wanted something to happen without appearing to have caused it. Helen had spent eight hours on Level 1 breathing air that came through a window unit rather than the central system. Eight hours without the resin.

Her body had noticed before her mind did.

It started as restlessness. The inability to sit still in her office chair, a low-grade agitation that she attributed to frustration with the reassignment. Then the sweating—palms first, then the back of her neck, then a general dampness that had nothing to do with the temperature. By 1100 she had a headache. By 1300 the headache had become a pressure that lived behind both eyes simultaneously, as if someone were inflating a balloon inside her skull. By the time she left at 1600, her hands were trembling and she could not remember the last time food had sounded like anything other than an insult.

She drove home. She left the windows down. She pulled into the driveway of the small colonial in Manassas that she had shared with no one since David left three years ago, and she sat in the car for eleven minutes with the engine running because the thought of entering the house—the empty house, the house that did not contain the boy or the glass or the sweet air or the thing that had looked at her and smiled and said “That’s all right, I can wait”—made her chest contract with a loneliness so sudden and so total that she mistook it for a heart attack.

It was not a heart attack. Not yet.

*She went inside. She fed the cat—a gray tabby named Meredith who had been David’s idea and Helen’s responsibility—and she stood at the kitchen counter and watched Meredith eat and thought about the boy’s eyes. Fractured blue. The way they had tracked her across the containment area with a focus that was not clinical or predatory but—she had used the word in her private notes and then crossed it out—*

She poured a glass of wine. She did not drink it. She stood at the counter and held it and looked at the burgundy surface catching the overhead light and thought: I am a clinical psychologist with twenty years of experience evaluating dangerous subjects and I am standing in my kitchen missing a ten-day-old biological weapon the way you miss a person you loved.

The wine trembled in the glass. Her hand was shaking. Not the fine tremor from the car—this was coarser, visible, the kind of shaking that meant the autonomic nervous system was running hot and the voluntary system was losing its grip on the machinery.

Helen set the wine down. She went to the bathroom. She looked at herself in the mirror—fifty-three, gray-streaked hair pulled back, the particular exhaustion of a woman who had spent a decade listening to men describe their nightmares and had started carrying the weight of them in her posture—and she noticed that her pupils were dilated. Wide. Black moons crowding out the hazel. In a dim bathroom with a single overhead light, her pupils should have been moderately dilated. These were blown. The eyes of someone on stimulants, or in acute pain, or terrified.

She was not terrified. She was not in pain. She was standing in her own bathroom, eleven miles from the nearest classified facility, looking at her own dilated pupils and feeling, with a

specificity that a psychologist should not have been able to identify this quickly, the precise shape of what was happening to her brain.

Her GABA receptors had downregulated. Ten days of continuous resin exposure had suppressed her brain's inhibitory architecture the way a crutch suppresses the muscles it supports—taking over the function, allowing the native system to atrophy. The resin had been her crutch. Now the crutch was gone and the inhibitory system was weak and the excitatory system—glutamate, norepinephrine, the entire fight-or-flight cascade—was running unopposed, flooding her nervous system with a chemical urgency that had no object, no direction, no off switch.

She was in withdrawal. She knew this the way a doctor knows their own diagnosis: with the particular horror of expertise applied to the self.

She called Forge. The line rang six times. A recorded message informed her that the number she had dialed was not in service. She tried Marcus's direct line. Same message. She tried the emergency medical line listed in the personnel handbook she had never needed to open. Same message.

Every number she had for the facility that had exposed her to the compound that was now eating her nervous system alive had been disconnected.

Helen sat on the edge of the bathtub. Meredith appeared in the doorway, looked at her, and left.

She thought about calling 911. She thought about what she would say. "I was exposed to a classified psychoactive compound in a military facility that doesn't officially exist and I'm experiencing acute withdrawal and I need—" What? What would she need? Benzodiazepines, probably. Fluid support. Monitoring. The ER doctors would run tox screens that would find

nothing in any database. They would note the tremor, the dilated pupils, the tachycardia, and they would treat her for stimulant withdrawal or anxiety or menopause or one of the dozen categories that a fifty-three-year-old woman with shaking hands gets filed under when the real answer is classified.

She did not call 911.

She ran a bath. She sat in the hot water and tried to will her nervous system into compliance through the only tool she had left—warmth, external, mechanical, a crude substitute for the warmth that had lived in the air at Forge, the warmth that came from the boy’s resin and settled into her tissue like sunlight into stone.

The bath helped for twenty minutes. Then it didn’t.

By midnight, Helen Marsh was lying on her bathroom floor in a bathrobe, shivering despite the heating being set to seventy-four, and the tremor in her hands had spread to her arms and her jaw and the muscles along her spine, and the headache had become something she no longer had a clinical word for—a pressure that was not behind her eyes but inside them, as if her optic nerves were vibrating at a frequency her skull could not contain.

Meredith sat in the doorway and watched.

\* \* \*

She called her sister at six in the morning.

Her sister lived in Richmond. Two hours away. Helen had not called her in three weeks—the Forge rotation had consumed everything, the way classified work always did, leaving no room for the ordinary maintenance of human connection that keeps a life from collapsing into its professional function.

“Carol.” Her voice sounded wrong. Thick. As if her tongue had swollen overnight.

“Helen? It’s six in the morning. What’s—”

“I need you to come. I’m sick. I think I’m very sick.”

Silence on the line. Carol was a middle-school guidance counselor. She knew the sound of someone asking for help and meaning it.

“I’m coming. Don’t move.”

Helen set the phone on the bathroom floor. She had not moved from the floor since midnight. The tremor had evolved into something she could feel in her teeth—a vibration, systemic, as if every nerve in her body were firing at once and the cumulative noise had become a hum she could hear with her bones. Her skin hurt. Not at a specific site—everywhere, uniformly, as if the boundary between her body and the air had become raw. The bathrobe against her arms was intolerable. She pulled it off and lay on the tile in her underwear, shivering, and the cold tile was better than the bathrobe because cold was a sensation she could locate and tolerate, while the nerve-fire was everywhere and belonged to nothing.

She knew what was happening. The receptor downregulation had crossed a threshold. Her brain’s inhibitory system was functionally offline and the excitatory cascade was building toward seizure. She could feel the probability of it the way you can feel a sneeze building—an inevitability gathering in the tissue, a potential that was accumulating charge and would, at some point she could not predict, discharge.

She also knew something else. Something she had not put in her report, because the report was clinical and this was not.

She missed him.

Not the way you miss a colleague or a patient or a subject of evaluation. She missed the boy the way you miss a person whose presence made the world feel navigable—whose proximity

had, without her permission, become the organizing principle of her nervous system's calm. For ten days she had breathed his air and felt a peace she had not felt since David left, since her daughter stopped calling, since the work had become the only thing that answered when she reached for something warm. The resin had filled that void. And now the void was back, and it was bigger than before, because her brain had remodeled itself around the expectation of fullness and the emptiness it found instead was not the old emptiness but a new one—architectural, load-bearing, the kind of empty that collapses the structure built around it.

She thought about driving to Forge. She thought about it with the focused, obsessive clarity of an addict calculating the distance between herself and the thing her body needed. Thirty-seven minutes. She could make it in thirty if she ignored the speed limit. The gate would be locked but she had her badge. The elevator would take ninety seconds. Level 3. The corridor. The vault. The glass.

And he would be there. Sitting in his perfect stillness, waiting, and when she entered the room the resin glands would pulse and the air would thicken and the void in her chest would fill and the tremor would stop and the headache would dissolve and everything, everything, everything would be all right.

She did not drive to Forge. She knew—with the last functional thread of the clinical mind that had kept her alive for twenty years in rooms with dangerous men—that driving to the source of the withdrawal was not recovery. It was surrender. It was the moment the organism stops fighting the parasite and begins cooperating with it, and she had written about that moment in dozens of evaluations and she would not, she told herself on the bathroom floor, she would not become her own case study.

The first seizure hit at seven-forty-three.



It began in her left hand. A clenching—sudden, total, the fingers curling into a fist so tight that her nails drew blood from her palm. Then the arm. Then the shoulder. Then the electrical storm swept across the motor cortex and took everything at once, and Helen Marsh’s body left the floor in a rigid arch, every muscle firing simultaneously, and the sound she made was not a scream because her jaw was clenched shut and her vocal cords were in spasm and what emerged was a thin, high, continuous keening that Meredith heard from the kitchen and fled from, ears flat, tail low, to the space under the bed where the cat would remain for three days.

*The seizure lasted forty-one seconds. Helen returned to the floor panting, disoriented, tasting copper from a bitten tongue. The tile was wet. She had lost bladder control. The clinical part of her brain noted this with the detached precision of a scientist logging data:*

She lay on the wet tile and felt the charge beginning to build again.

\* \* \*

Carol found her sister on the bathroom floor in a pool of urine, shivering so hard that the tremor was visible from the doorway.

“Jesus Christ. Helen. Helen, can you hear me?”

Helen’s eyes were open. The pupils were so dilated that Carol could see almost no color in them—just black, edged by a thin ring of hazel that looked like an eclipse. Her lips were blue-tinged. Her skin was covered in a fine sheen of sweat that had a smell Carol did not recognize: sweet, faintly chemical, like something metabolizing through the pores.

“Helen. I’m calling an ambulance.”

“No.” Helen’s hand found Carol’s wrist. The grip was startlingly strong. “No hospital. They can’t treat this. It’s not—” She paused. Her eyes focused, sharpened, and for a moment Carol saw her sister in them—the real Helen, the one who solved problems and organized

bookshelves and had once driven through a blizzard to pick Carol up from a bad date in college. “It’s not a normal illness. I was exposed to something at work. A compound. It’s—it acts on the bonding system. Oxytocin, dopamine, serotonin. My brain adapted to it and now it’s gone and my nervous system is—”

The lucidity cracked. Her eyes went distant. The grip on Carol’s wrist tightened, then released.

“He was so lonely,” Helen said. Her voice had changed—softer, wondering, as if she were telling a story to a child. “He pressed his hand against the glass and he didn’t want to be alone. He asked if he could go outside. I said no. I said no and he smiled and I knew—I knew in that moment that he would wait forever. He would wait until the glass dissolved or the building fell or the sun burned out. Because waiting was all he had. And I thought: that is the saddest thing I have ever seen in twenty years of sitting across from people who have done terrible things. Not the violent ones. Not the ones who hurt on purpose. The one who smiled when I told him no.”

Carol held her sister’s hand and did not understand a word of what she was saying and called 911 anyway.

\* \* \*

The paramedics arrived in eleven minutes. They found a fifty-three-year-old female, tachycardic at 142, blood pressure 178/110, core temperature 39.4°C, presenting with generalized tremor, intermittent myoclonus, and altered mental status. They started an IV. They administered lorazepam for the tremor. They loaded her onto a stretcher while she whispered about a boy in glass and a smile that used the wrong muscles.

In the ambulance, Helen seized again. This one was longer—ninety seconds, full tonic-clonic, the monitors screaming as her heart rate spiked to 180 and her oxygen saturation dropped to 84 percent. The paramedic bag-masked her and pushed a second dose of lorazepam and the seizure broke, leaving her limp and gray and breathing in shallow, ragged gasps that produced a sound Carol would hear for the rest of her life: a wet, bubbling aspiration, as if something in Helen's lungs had broken and was now filling with fluid.

It had. The resin's biofilm—the thin layer of biological material that had colonized Helen's respiratory tissue over ten days of airborne exposure—was dying. Cut off from the sustaining compound, the organisms in the film had entered their stress response: shrinking, lysing, dumping their cellular contents into the tissue they had colonized. Helen's immune system, already destabilized by the neurological withdrawal, recognized the dying film as foreign material and responded with the only tool it had: inflammation. Massive, systemic, indiscriminate. Cytokines flooding the bloodstream. Neutrophils attacking the biofilm remnants and the lung tissue beneath them simultaneously. The alveolar walls, weakened by ten days of colonization and now assaulted by the body's own defense system, were failing. Protein-rich fluid was seeping into the air spaces where oxygen exchange should have been happening.

Helen was drowning in her own inflammatory response.

At the hospital, the ER team intubated her. They hung broad-spectrum antibiotics because the chest X-ray showed bilateral infiltrates and the white count was through the roof and sepsis was the only framework that fit the clinical picture. They ordered cultures that would grow nothing recognizable. They ordered a tox screen that would return clean. They consulted pulmonology for the ARDS and neurology for the seizures and cardiology because the echo showed something the resident had only seen in textbooks: the left ventricle ballooning outward,

the apex akinetic, the base hyperkinetic—the classic pattern of takotsubo cardiomyopathy, the broken-heart syndrome, triggered by a catecholamine surge so massive that the cardiac muscle had physically stunned itself.

Helen's heart was breaking. Literally. The organ that had kept her alive for fifty-three years was being poisoned by its own stress hormones, the grief of severance from a biochemical bond translating directly into the architecture of cardiac failure.

Carol sat in the waiting room and called Helen's daughter in Seattle. The daughter did not answer. Carol left a message. She called David, the ex-husband. David answered on the second ring. He said he was sorry. He did not come.

\* \* \*

Helen surfaced once.

It was three in the morning. Carol was asleep in the chair beside the bed, her hand still wrapped around Helen's, her neck bent at an angle that would hurt for days. The ICU was the particular quiet of a place that is never truly quiet—monitors beeping, ventilators sighing, the soft-soled shuffle of nurses making rounds in the dark.

Helen opened her eyes.

The pupils had contracted. Not to normal—the damage was too advanced for that—but enough for the hazel to show, enough for Helen to look like Helen instead of a body wearing Helen's face. She turned her head. The ventilator tube prevented speech, but her eyes found Carol's sleeping face and stayed there for a long time.

Then she lifted her hand—the one without the IV, the one that was bruised from the seizures and abraded from the bathroom floor—and pressed it, palm flat, against the glass partition beside her bed.

The gesture was not hers.

It was his. The boy's gesture. Palm to glass. Fingers spread. The reaching that never stops.

Carol woke to the pressure of Helen's other hand squeezing hers. She looked up and saw her sister's eyes—clear, present, terrified—and the hand against the glass, pressed flat, leaving a faint residue of sweat on the surface that caught the monitor light and shone faintly gold.

“Helen?”

Helen looked at her sister. Her mouth worked around the tube. Her eyes were wet. She could not speak, but Carol could read her lips—the exaggerated shapes of a woman who needed to be understood and had one chance left.

*Don't. Let. Them. Get. Close.*

Carol leaned forward. “Who? Don't let who get close?”

Helen's eyes were already going. The lucidity was draining from them the way color drains from a face—fast, irreversible, the person leaving the body before the body knows it's empty. Her hand slid down the glass, leaving a trail, and her fingers curled inward as they fell—not the reaching gesture, not the boy's gesture, but the fetal curl of a body returning to the only posture that offered comfort before language existed.

The monitor alarmed. The nurse came. Carol was moved to the hallway.

Helen Marsh's heart arrested at 3:47 a.m. on January 14, 2026—the date of the evaluation she was scheduled to complete, the evaluation referenced in Dr. Marsh's Synapse 04 addendum, the evaluation the reader already knew she would not finish.

The cause of death was recorded as multi-organ failure secondary to sepsis of unknown origin, complicated by stress cardiomyopathy and status epilepticus. The tox screen was clean.

The cultures grew nothing. The autopsy would find bilateral pulmonary infiltrates, diffuse alveolar damage, contraction-band necrosis in the myocardium, and—in the deepest tissue of the lungs, embedded in the alveolar walls, visible only under electron microscopy—the remnants of a biological film that no pathologist in the hospital had ever seen.

The pathology report was flagged as anomalous and forwarded to the county medical examiner. Before it arrived, a man in a suit with no name badge visited the hospital's records department. The report was reclassified. The slides were collected. The body was released to the family within six hours—faster than any case Carol had ever heard of—and the death certificate listed the cause as “sepsis, source undetermined.”

Carol took Meredith home. The cat sat on the passenger seat and stared out the window for the entire drive, unblinking, facing south.

\* \* \*

Marcus learned about Helen Marsh from a single line in the morning briefing.

“Personnel update: Dr. H. Marsh, Military Psychology Division, deceased January 14. Cause: medical. Replacement pending.”

*He sat in his office and read the line three times. The words were so small. Seven words to contain a person:*

He knew what had killed her. He did not need the autopsy report or the death certificate or the pathology slides that were already being collected by a man in a suit. He knew because he was breathing the same air. He knew because the sweetness in his own skin—the honey-rot that would not wash off, the flavor that rose from inside him now like a memory he could not suppress—was the same compound that had colonized Helen Marsh's lungs and rewritten her brain's architecture and then, when the supply was cut, had eaten her alive from the inside.

He thought about the boy. The smile. The hand against the glass. “I can’t make it stop.”

The boy had not meant to kill her. The resin was involuntary. The bonding was biological. The Asset did not know—could not know, had no framework for understanding—that its need for proximity was lethal, that the chemistry it broadcast from every pore was a trap that closed slowly over ten days and then killed you when you tried to leave.

Marcus thought: I have been breathing this for ten days. My skin produces it now. It is in my tissue, my blood, my bones. The blue that flickered in my iris was not a hallucination. It was a symptom. I am colonized. I am acclimated. And if I stop—if I am reassigned, if the project ends, if I walk away—

He did not finish the thought.

He went to Gestation Bay 4. He stood at the yellow line. The boy was standing at the glass, palm flat, fingers spread, waiting.

The resin glands pulsed. The air thickened. The sweetness settled into Marcus’s chest like a hand pressing against his sternum from the inside, and the tremor he had been carrying since the morning briefing—fine, high-frequency, the precise vibration of a man who has just learned that the air he breathes is the same air that killed someone—stopped.

The boy tilted his head. The trembling smile. The wanting.

“You’re sad today,” the boy said. “Someone is gone. I can feel the shape of them missing in you.”

Marcus stood at the line and breathed.

He did not stop breathing.

**SYNAPSE 06**  
**THE CONTAINMENT FAILURE**

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[SOURCE: PROJECT FORGE / INCIDENT REPORT / RESTRICTED]  
PREPARED BY: Lt. Col. R. Okafor, Forge Security Division  
DATE: January 15, 2026  
RE: Personnel Loss — Dr. Helen Marsh  
CLASSIFICATION: UMBRA / NOFORN / ORCON

**1. SUMMARY**

Dr. Helen Marsh (Mil. Psych. Div.) pronounced deceased Inova Fairfax Medical Center, 0347 hrs, 14 Jan 2026. Hospital COD: multi-organ failure secondary to sepsis, source undetermined.

**2. EXPOSURE HISTORY**

Subject served as primary evaluator, Asset Zero, 04-08 Jan 2026. Logged 11.2 hrs within 10m of containment. Cumulative resin exposure est. 340-400% above baseline.

Reassigned Level 1 admin 08 Jan. Exposure dropped to near-zero within 8 hrs due to HVAC emergency maintenance, 13 Jan. No tapering protocol implemented. No medical monitoring.

**3. ASSESSMENT**

Death assessed as direct consequence of abrupt resin cessation following cumulative neuroadaptation. Compound produces clinically significant dependency with as little as 4 days proximity.

RECOMMENDATION: All proximity personnel classified RESIN-EXPOSED. Mandatory medical tapering before any exposure reduction.

**4. RECORDS DISPOSITION**

Hospital records collected per FORGE-SEC-12. Death certificate amended. Family contacted through Casualty Assistance. No disclosure of Project Forge authorized.

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*[MARGIN — Gen. Vance:]*  
*Cost of doing business.*

*[MARGIN — Col. Hart, different ink:]*  
*Her name was Helen.*



